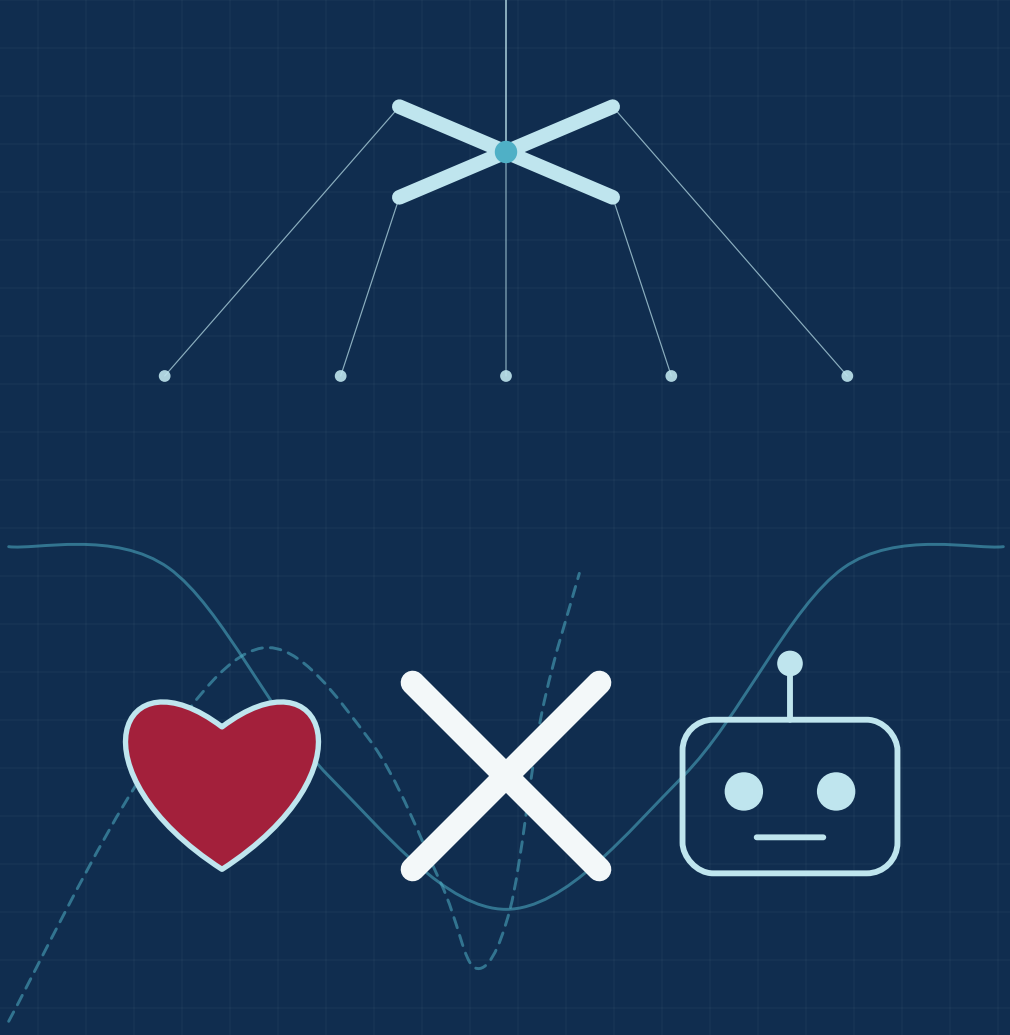


The Anthropic Valley

Grace, Finitude, and the Superimposed Curve in Love, Death & Robots

2026

Grace appears most purely in that human form which has either no consciousness at all or an infinite one; that is, in the puppet or in the god.

Heinrich von Kleist, “Über das Marionettentheater” (1810)

And now I see with eye serene
The very pulse of the machine;
A Being breathing thoughtful breath,
A Traveller between life and death

William Wordsworth, “She Was a Phantom of Delight” (1807)

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the title of *Love, Death & Robots* (Netflix, 2019–2025; created by Tim Miller, executive-produced with David Fincher) is not an inventory of themes but a diagram, and that the forty-five shorts released across its four volumes constitute a sustained, if uncoordinated, exploration of the space that diagram describes. The diagram is reconstructed by superimposing two curves separated by one hundred and sixty years. The first is Heinrich von Kleist's "Über das Marionettentheater" (1810), which plots grace against consciousness and finds it purest at the two extremes, in the marionette that has no consciousness and the god that has an infinite one, while the self-regarding human sinks between them. The second is Masahiro Mori's "Bukimi no tani" (1970), which plots affinity against human likeness and discovers a sudden trough, populated by the prosthetic hand, the corpse and the zombie, just short of the healthy human summit.

Superimposed, the two curves yield a figure this study names **the anthropic valley**: the region in which the human appears simultaneously as the summit of likeness and the trough of grace. The anthology's governing operation, the thesis contends, is to relocate the uncanny from the machine to the human. Its robots are innocent, comic, or serenely graceful; its cats are sovereign; its moons, swarms, sirens and deities occupy the far peak; and the human species, acquisitive, militarized, voyeuristic and mortal, is the thing that does not quite pass for alive.

Within this topology the three titular terms resolve into operators rather than topics. *Robots* names the slope of the zero, the grace of mechanism, from the pool-cleaning origin of "Zima Blue" to the string-puppet rock band of "Can't Stop". *Death* names the valley floor and the process this study terms **exanimation**: the forced conversion of the lived body (*Leib*) into the object-body (*Körper*), of a *who* into a *what*, traced through "The Drowned Giant", "Pop Squad", "Jibaro" and the series' expendable soldiers. *Love* names the only vector that crosses the valley, a **xenophilic traverse** directed almost without exception at the nonhuman: the mechanical fox, the doomed dropship, the simulated lover, the moon that wishes to know its visitor. Read through Diotima's account of Eros as *metaxy*, the daimonic in-between, the valley proves to be not merely the trough of grace but the habitat of love. The robot does not desire because it lacks nothing; the god does not desire because it lacks nothing; only the creature suspended between them, finite and partial, can. The peaks may give care, which the study distinguishes as *agape*, but only the valley generates *eros*.

The argument proceeds genealogically (*Métal Hurlant*, *Heavy Metal*, the pulp archive, the New Wave, cyberpunk, the British new space opera), theoretically (Kleist, Mori, Jentsch, Freud, Bergson, Benjamin, Adorno and Horkheimer, Arendt, Haraway, Ba-

taille, Derrida, Nygren), and through close reading of the complete corpus. It then turns to form: the frameless anthology, Netflix's experiment in randomized episode order, and animation itself as an art that manufactures life from serial stillness and therefore inhabits the valley as its technical condition. It concludes with fifteen theses and a trajectory atlas that plots every episode on the superimposed curve.

Prefatory Note

Corpus

The corpus comprises the forty-five episodes released to date: eighteen in Volume I (15 March 2019), eight in Volume II (14 May 2021), nine in Volume III (20 May 2022) and ten in Volume IV (15 May 2025). No fifth volume had been confirmed at the time of writing. Episodes are cited by title and volume in square brackets, for example "Zima Blue" [I], rather than by number. The choice is principled. Netflix released Volume I in four distinct episode orders assigned to viewers at random and has since re-sequenced the volumes, so that the numeric order of the anthology is unstable by design. Chapter VIII treats that instability as a formal property of the work rather than a bibliographic nuisance.

The problem of authorship

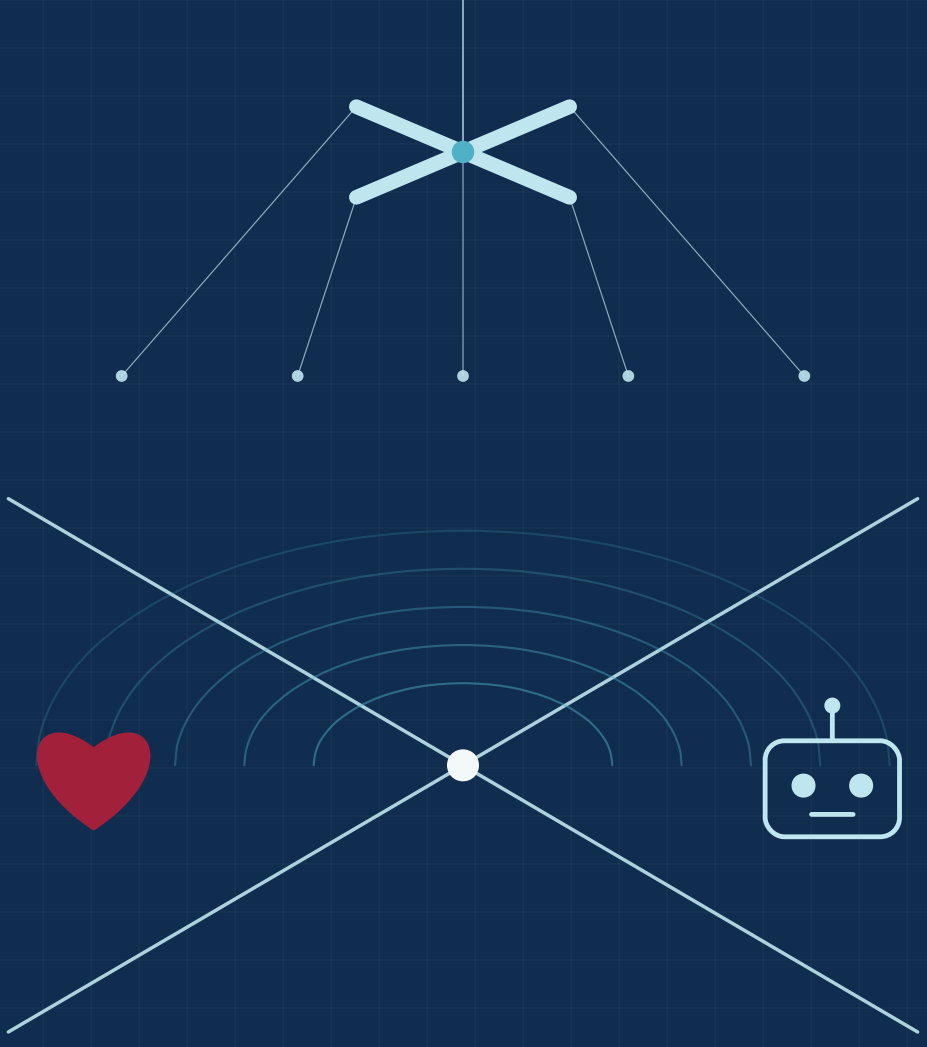
Love, Death & Robots has a creator but not an author in the Romantic sense. Miller functions as curator and showrunner; the great majority of episodes adapt short fiction by other writers; Philip Gelatt scripted more episodes than anyone else; Jennifer Yuh Nelson served as supervising director from Volume II; and production was distributed across dozens of studios on several continents, coordinated by Miller's Blur Studio. The series' philosophy is therefore emergent: it arises from selection, adaptation and juxtaposition rather than from a single intending consciousness. Accordingly, the "originators" of its ideas are traced in three registers, which the argument keeps distinct throughout. *Source* designates the author of the adapted story. *Lineage* designates the philosophical or literary tradition on which that author demonstrably draws. *Resonance* designates a tradition activated by the work, or by the juxtaposition of works within the anthology, whether or not any creator intended it. Claims of resonance are offered as interpretation, never as attribution.

Method

The study combines close reading, comparative mythography and media philosophy under a single procedure, here called **trajectory reading**. Each episode is treated as a path across the superimposed curve constructed in Chapter II: a descent toward the valley floor, an ascent toward one of the two peaks, a traverse between them, or a loop that returns to its own beginning. The procedure is deliberately topological rather than taxonomic. It does not ask which of the three titular words an episode is "about"; it asks where an episode begins, where it ends, and what it costs to move between those

points. Dialogue and secondary sources are paraphrased unless a brief quotation is indispensable; translations of Kleist, Schlegel and Montaigne are the present author's.





Introduction

The Title as Diagram

Introduction

The Title as Diagram

The title *Love, Death & Robots* is customarily read as a list; it should be read as a map. Critical reception has largely treated the series as a showroom of uneven quality, its coherence either technical (a demonstration reel for the world's animation studios) or nominal (a receptacle into which any short featuring a heart, a corpse or a machine may be poured). The aggregate critical consensus on Volume I judged its ambitions undermined by an appetite for gore and titillation, and later volumes were praised chiefly for craftsmanship. The series' own paratexts encourage the nominal reading: each episode, it is said, connects to one or more of the three titular concepts. The result is a hermeneutic of sorting, in which episodes are filed under love, death or robots and the anthology dissolves into its bins.

Taxonomy is the anthology's default interpretive mode and its characteristic trap. The three terms of the title are not parallel categories; they belong to different logical kinds. Love is a relation, death is a limit, and a robot is a class of entity. A sequence that conjoins a relation, a limit and an entity is not an inventory but a syntax awaiting a parse. The series' emblem makes the point graphically. It renders the title as three pictograms, a heart, a cross and a robot's head, and the middle sign is not the skull that iconographic convention would have supplied for mortality but an X. An X is at once a cancellation and a crossing. Read diagrammatically, the emblem sets a relation and an entity on either side of a chiasm, and the present study takes that chiasm at its word: the X marks the point at which two curves cross.

The two curves

The first curve is drawn in Heinrich von Kleist's essay on the marionette theatre, published in four instalments of the *Berliner Abendblätter* in December 1810. Its interlocutor, the dancer Herr C., argues that marionettes possess a grace no human dancer can attain, because their soul coincides with their centre of gravity and they are therefore incapable of affectation. Grace, he concludes, appears most purely in the body that has either no consciousness or an infinite one: in the puppet or in the god. The human, possessed of finite and self-observing consciousness, falls between. The second curve is drawn in Masahiro Mori's two-page article of 1970 in the Japanese journal *Energy*. Mori proposes that our affinity for an artificial figure rises as it comes to resemble a human, then plunges abruptly just before full resemblance, into a trough occupied by

the prosthetic hand, the corpse and, when motion is added, the zombie, before recovering at the summit of the healthy human being.

The two curves share an astonishing amount of furniture. Both include the puppet, which Kleist praises and which Mori places, in the form of the Bunraku figure, high on his graph. Both include the prosthesis: Kleist's Herr C. admires the poise of amputees dancing on artificial legs, while Mori's prosthetic hand marks the valley's descent. Both deny that resemblance to the human is a monotonic good. They disagree on one point only, but it is decisive. For Mori the healthy human is the summit; for Kleist the human is the trough. When the curves are superimposed, the human therefore appears twice, as the peak of one figure and the floor of the other. The region of that doubled appearance is what this study calls **the anthropic valley**.

The thesis

The argument of this dissertation is that *Love, Death & Robots* is the site at which these two curves are made to coincide, and that the effect of their coincidence is to relocate the uncanny from the machine to the human. The claim can be tested against the corpus with unusual directness. In a series whose title names robots, robots are almost never the source of dread. The exceptions confirm the rule by their register: the maintenance unit of "Life Hutch" [II] is a malfunction, not a will, and the homicidal household devices of "Automated Customer Service" [II] belong to farce. Dread belongs to humans: to the colonial governor who drugs a fox-spirit he has hired as a courtesan and has her legs surgically replaced with machinery in "Good Hunting" [I], to the conquistador who flays a siren of her gold in "Jibaro" [III], to the crew of "Bad Travelling" [III], who vote unanimously to deliver a predator to an inhabited island, and to the navigator who falsifies their vote and kills them all to stop it, to the immortal police who hunt down and kill children in "Pop Squad" [II], to the townspeople who dismember a god-like corpse in "The Drowned Giant" [II], and to the survivalists and billionaires whose greed the robots of "Three Robots: Exit Strategies" [III] calmly catalogue. The robots watch, archive, serve and withdraw. The humans do the things that do not pass for alive.

Within the anthropic valley the three titular terms cease to be topics and become operators. *Robots* designates the slope of the zero, the region of grace without reflexivity, which the series populates with machines, puppets and, decisively, cats. *Death* designates the valley floor and a process this study names **exanimation**, the forced conversion of a lived body into an object-body, of a *who* into a *what*. *Love* designates the only vector capable of crossing the valley, a **xenophilic traverse** that in this anthology is directed with remarkable consistency at the nonhuman. Two further claims follow. The first is that the valley, far from being merely a trough of grace, is the habitat of Eros, which Diotima in Plato's *Symposium* defines as an intermediate being, neither mortal

nor immortal, born of resource and poverty. Robots and gods may care, but they do not desire, because they lack nothing; only the valley-dweller loves in the erotic sense. The second is that the two peaks coincide. The robot artist of "Zima Blue" [I], dissolving himself back into a pool-cleaning machine, and the astronaut of "The Very Pulse of the Machine" [III], dissolving herself into the mind of Io, perform the same gesture seen from opposite slopes, as Kleist anticipated when he compared the return of grace to an image that vanishes into infinity in a concave mirror and reappears directly before the eye.

Contributions

The study makes four contributions. To the theory of the uncanny, it proposes that the deepest uncanniness belongs not to the almost-human, as Ernst Jentsch, Freud and Mori variously argued, but to the human regarded from the vantage of the nonhuman, a vantage the anthology adopts systematically and which Jacques Derrida, standing naked before his cat, identified as the inaugural scene of the question of the animal. To the study of speculative fiction, it identifies a figure it calls the **post-revolutionary machine**: the robot that arrives after the revolt imagined by Karel Čapek in 1920, as heir, archivist or renunciant, while the revolt itself migrates to organic life, to yogurt, cats, swarms, rats and monstrous infants. To animation theory, it argues that animation is the metaxic medium par excellence, an art that produces life from a succession of still images and therefore crosses the valley twenty-four times a second. To the ethics of the posthuman, finally, it offers an alternative both to transhumanist ascent and to antihumanist misanthropy: a defence of the human not as summit but as habitat, the place where love is generated precisely because grace is absent.

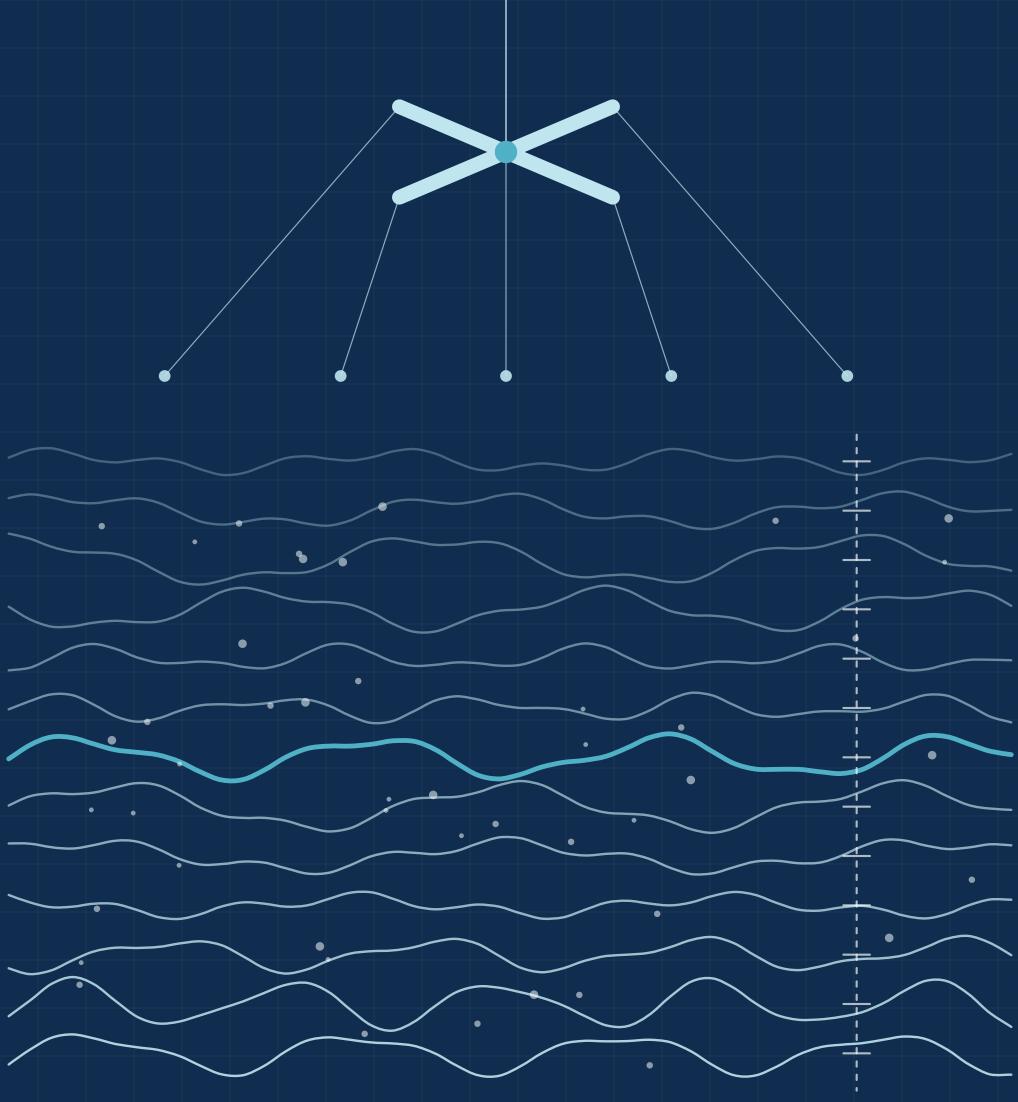
Limits and procedure

No claim is made that the series is a coherent philosophical system. It is commercial, uneven and at times adolescent, and its sexual politics, particularly in Volume I, drew sustained and substantive criticism, which Chapter VII examines. The claim is narrower and, it is hoped, more interesting: that the anthology's juxtapositions disclose a system its individual parts do not possess. Walter Benjamin observed that ideas relate to objects as constellations relate to stars; the stars are not altered by the figure, yet the figure is real. The anthropic valley is such a figure.

Chapter I reconstructs the series' genealogy from *Métal Hurlant* through the pulp archive, the New Wave and cyberpunk, and argues that the absence of a framing host is its most consequential inheritance. Chapter II constructs the superimposed curve in detail and defines the study's terms. Chapter III examines the slope of the zero: robots, marionettes, cyborgs and cats. Chapter IV descends to the valley floor: exanimation, immortality and the soldier's body. Chapter V traces love's traverses and their failure.

Chapter VI excavates the theology hidden inside the materialist machine of science fiction. Chapter VII turns to spectacle, scale and the politics of the gaze. Chapter VIII addresses the anthology as form and animation as medium. The conclusion distils the argument into fifteen theses, and an appendix plots every episode on the curve.





Chapter

I

Genealogy

Métal Hurlant, *the Pulp Archive, and the Frameless Anthology*

Chapter I

Genealogy

Love, Death & Robots descends from an anthology with a frame and inherits everything except the frame. This chapter reconstructs the lineage in five strata, the French adult *bande dessinée*, the American pulp short story, the British and American New Wave, cyberpunk, and the post-1990 new space opera with its satellites, before turning to the anthology tradition proper. Its conclusion is that the series' most consequential inheritance is an absence: it has no host, and the work of unification that a host once performed passes to its title.

1.1 From *Métal Hurlant* to the Loc-Nar

The magazine *Métal Hurlant*, launched in Paris in the mid-1970s by Les Humanoïdes Associés (Jean Giraud, known as Moebius, Philippe Druillet, Jean-Pierre Dionnet and Bernard Farkas), established the premise that speculative fiction could be an adult visual art, at once erotic, metaphysical and indifferent to the moral pedagogy of the American comic. Moebius's wordless *Arzach* sequences demonstrated that a narrative could be carried by line and landscape alone; Druillet's cathedral-sized spacecraft demonstrated that the sublime could be drawn. The licensed American edition, *Heavy Metal*, followed in 1977, and in 1981 Gerald Potterton's anthology film of the same name translated the magazine into animation. The film is unified by a device: the Loc-Nar, a glowing green sphere presented as the sum of all evils, which passes from segment to segment and corrupts whatever it touches. The frame is not incidental. It installs a metaphysics, a single malign substance of which every tale is a mode, and it turns the anthology into an inverted theodicy.

The Fincher and Miller project began as a remake of that film. Announced in 2008 with Paramount, it gathered a roster of prospective segment directors that included James Cameron, Zack Snyder, Kevin Eastman, Gore Verbinski and Guillermo del Toro, before the studio withdrew that summer. Years of meetings followed; the project was reportedly judged too risqué for mainstream audiences, and it reached production only when Netflix agreed to finance it as a series. Miller has credited the 1981 film with inspiring a generation of animators who wanted to make work for adults. What did not survive the transition was the Loc-Nar. *Love, Death & Robots* has no malign sphere, no narrator, no recurring device that passes from story to story. The frame has migrated into the title, and the title is not a substance but a set of coordinates.

1.2 The pulp archive

The second stratum is the American pulp short story. Hugo Gernsback's *Amazing Stories* (1926) made the short the native form of modern science fiction, and the magazines that followed it, John W. Campbell's *Astounding* foremost, turned the form into a laboratory for the "idea story": a premise, an extrapolation, a reversal. Isaac Asimov's robot stories of the 1940s, organized around the Three Laws, domesticated the revolt Čapek had staged in *R.U.R.* (1920) by subjecting the machine to an axiomatics of obedience. A parallel tradition, *Weird Tales* (1923) and H. P. Lovecraft above all, supplied cosmic horror, the intuition of an indifferent universe that would rather not be known. Both lineages survive in the corpus. The pulp reversal, the "kicker" that recontextualizes everything before it, structures "Sonnie's Edge" [I], "Beyond the Aquila Rift" [I], "Three Robots" [I] and "Snow in the Desert" [II]. Lovecraft's cosmic indifferentism informs "In Vaulted Halls Entombed" [III] directly and "The Secret War" [I], "Sucker of Souls" [I] and "The Tall Grass" [II] by descent. The oldest source text in the corpus, Harlan Ellison's "Life Hutch" (1956), is a pulp-era story about a man pinned beneath a damaged robot that attacks anything that moves. The archaeological floor of the anthology is thus a machine that cannot distinguish motion from threat, an image to which Chapter III returns.

1.3 *Dangerous Visions* and the New Wave

The third stratum is the New Wave of the 1960s. Michael Moorcock's editorship of *New Worlds* from 1964 and J. G. Ballard's 1962 manifesto "Which Way to Inner Space?" redirected the genre from outer to inner space, from extrapolation to introspection, from the engineer's problem to the psychoanalyst's. Ballard's "The Drowned Giant" (1964), adapted in Volume II, is perhaps the New Wave's most perfect fable: no science, no future, only a colossal corpse on a beach and the community that degrades it. Ellison's anthology *Dangerous Visions* (1967) supplied the movement's commercial and ethical template: the anthology as a zone in which what the market forbids may be shown. The self-branding of *Love, Death & Robots* as adult, explicit and unsafe for work is a late and somewhat diminished echo of that program. Where Ellison's contributors transgressed the genre's taboos on sexuality, religion and politics, the series more often transgresses television's taboos on gore and nudity, and the distinction matters for the critique pursued in Chapter VII. Yet at its best, in "The Drowned Giant", "Fish Night" [I] or "The Very Pulse of the Machine" [III], the series recovers the New Wave's conviction that the speculative story is a vehicle for the interior life.

1.4 *Mirrorshades*: the cyberpunk spine

The fourth stratum is cyberpunk, and here the lineage is documentary rather than inferential. Bruce Sterling's anthology *Mirrorshades* (1986) defined the movement, and it

contained Marc Laidlaw's "400 Boys". Miller has said he read the story there in the 1980s, never forgot its strangeness, and adapted the screenplay himself for Volume IV. Sterling's own Shaper/Mechanist stories, "Swarm" and "Spider Rose" (both 1982), belong to the cycle that culminated in the novel *Schismatrix* (1985), and supervising director Jennifer Yuh Nelson has recalled that "Spider Rose" was among the stories already circulating in the Fincher and Miller pitches some fifteen years before Volume IV.

Sterling's cycle bequeaths the series its implicit political ontology of the posthuman. Shapers remake themselves through genetic and psychological engineering; Mechanists remake themselves through prosthesis and machinery. The anthology distributes its posthumans along exactly this axis. Its cyborg corridor is Mechanist: the beast-piloting fighter of "Sonnie's Edge", whose human body proves to be a decoy; the backed-up crew of "Blindspot" [I]; the armoured agent Hirald of "Snow in the Desert"; the chrome fox of "Good Hunting". Its engineered organisms are Shaper: the modded youths of "Ice" [II], the uplifted cats of "Three Robots", the gene-altered gladiators of "The Screaming of the Tyrannosaur" [IV], the bioengineered beasts of "Sonnie's Edge" itself. The series renders no verdict between the two programs. It shows both as routes out of the anthropic valley, and it shows both exacting a price in love.

1.5 The new space opera, the Texan weird, and the comic idiom

The fifth stratum is the most heterogeneous. Alastair Reynolds, the astrophysicist turned novelist whose "Zima Blue" and "Beyond the Aquila Rift" (both 2005) anchor Volume I, brings the deep-time scale of the British new space opera, in which personal identity is measured against centuries and parsecs. Neal Asher, adapted three times ("Snow in the Desert", "Bad Travelling" [III], "Mason's Rats" [III]), brings a grotesque biological imagination and a sharp sense of the economy of predation. Michael Swanwick, adapted twice ("Ice Age" [I], and "The Very Pulse of the Machine", which won the Hugo Award), brings a lyrical metaphysics. Joe R. Lansdale, also adapted three times ("The Dump" [I], "Fish Night", "The Tall Grass"), brings the vernacular sublime of the Texan weird, in which salesmen, scavengers and train passengers stumble into the numinous. Marko Kloos brings military science fiction ("Shape-Shifters" [I], "Lucky 13" [I]); Ken Liu brings the Chinese-American "silkpunk" fusion of folklore and engineering ("Good Hunting", 2012); Paolo Bacigalupi brings ecological and biopolitical dystopia ("Pop Squad", 2006).

Above all there is John Scalzi, the series' most frequently adapted author, with seven credits: "Three Robots", "When the Yogurt Took Over" [I], "Alternate Histories" [I], "Automated Customer Service", "Three Robots: Exit Strategies", "The Other Large Thing" [IV] and "Smart Appliances, Stupid Owners" [IV]. Scalzi is the anthology's house philosopher of the comic, and his recurrence is structurally significant. Every one of his contributions concerns the relation between human beings and their ma-

chines or successors, and every one is funny. Chapter III will argue that this is not a tonal accident but a theorem: in the anthropic valley, the comic is the register in which the human appears as mechanism. The remaining sources, from Rich Larson, Claudine Griggs, Alan Baxter, Dave Hutchinson, Stant Litore, John McNichol, Siobhan Carroll, Kirsten Cross, Steve Lewis, David W. Amendola, Joachim Heijndermans and Justin Coates, together with the original works of Alberto Mielgo ("The Witness" [I], "Jibaro" [III]), Vitaliy Shushko ("Blindspot"), Robert Bisi and Andy Lyon (the tilt-shift miniatures) and David Fincher ("Can't Stop" [IV]), complete a corpus that functions as a museum of movements. Nearly every major idiom of speculative fiction since 1926 is represented by at least one specimen. That breadth is what allows the anthology to disclose a metaphysics no single movement articulates: juxtaposition across idioms exposes invariants.

1.6 The anthology tradition and the problem of the host

The televisual anthology has almost always had a host. Rod Serling stepped into the frame of *The Twilight Zone* (1959–1964) to deliver the moral; *The Outer Limits* (1963–1965) seized the viewer's set through its "Control Voice"; the Cryptkeeper migrated from EC Comics to HBO's *Tales from the Crypt* (1989–1996) to cackle over each comeuppance. Where there is no host, there is usually a thesis: *Black Mirror* (2011–) is unified by the proposition that technology reflects and magnifies human appetite. The animated anthology has generally relied on a franchise or a theme. *Robot Carnival* (1987), which gathered Japanese directors including Katsuhiro Otomo around the single topic of robots, is the closest precedent for the present series in format and subject; *Memories* (1995), *The Animatrix* (2003), *Genius Party* (2007) and *Star Wars: Visions* (2021) are unified by a director's sensibility or an intellectual property; Blur's own *Secret Level* (2024) is unified by its source in video games.

Love, Death & Robots has neither host nor franchise nor explicit thesis. Its only recurring characters are the three robots of Scalzi's diptych and, through a continuity of voice casting that director Patrick Osborne has acknowledged, its cats. That the sole persistence granted in a frameless anthology should belong to robots and cats is, as Chapter III argues, itself a philosophical statement. The absence of a host transfers the labour of unification to two agencies: to the title, which becomes a coordinate system in place of a narrator, and to the viewer, who must assemble the constellation. Netflix's decision to randomize the order of Volume I, examined in Chapter VIII, radicalized the second transfer.

1.7 Fincher's polemic against the segment

The series also inherits a polemic about duration. Introducing it in 2019, Fincher argued against the twenty-two and forty-eight minute containers that advertising had

imposed on television, describing the habituated response to that segmentation as "anathema to storytelling" and insisting that a story should run exactly as long as maximum impact requires. The episodes accordingly range from a few minutes to around twenty. The polemic has a philosophical implication that its author need not have intended. A story whose length is determined by its own necessity rather than by an external schedule is a story with a proper death: it ends when it is finished, not when the slot expires. Edgar Allan Poe's doctrine of the single effect, achievable only in a work read at one sitting, finds here an industrial realization. The short is the mortal form, and an anthology of shorts is an anthology of finitudes.

1.8 Conclusion

Love, Death & Robots thus inherits a double archive: the idea-forms of a century of speculative fiction and the techniques of a century of animation, from hand-drawn line to photoreal simulation, stop-motion, tilt-shift miniature and live action. Its frame is not a narrator but a coordinate system. The next chapter reconstructs that system.

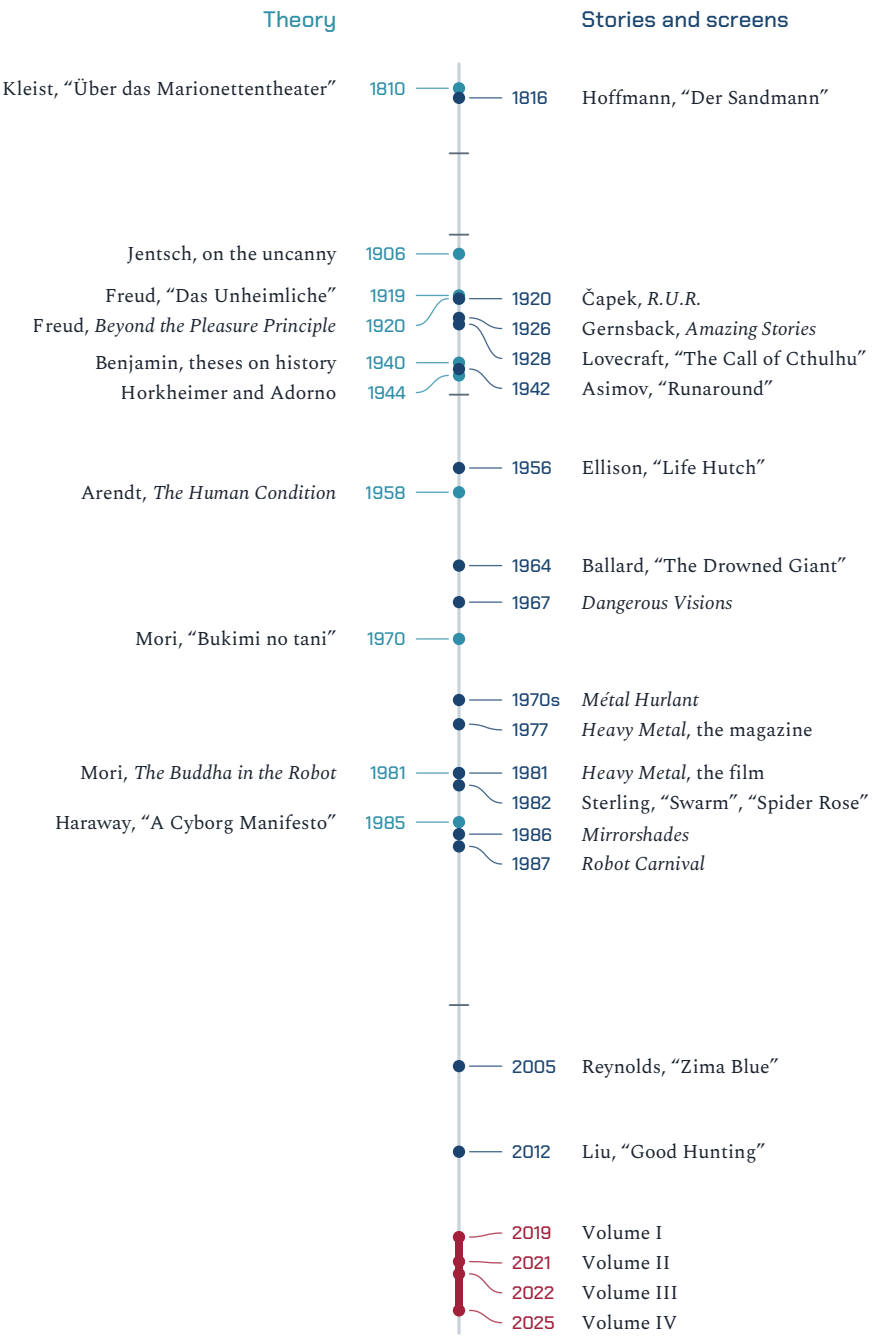
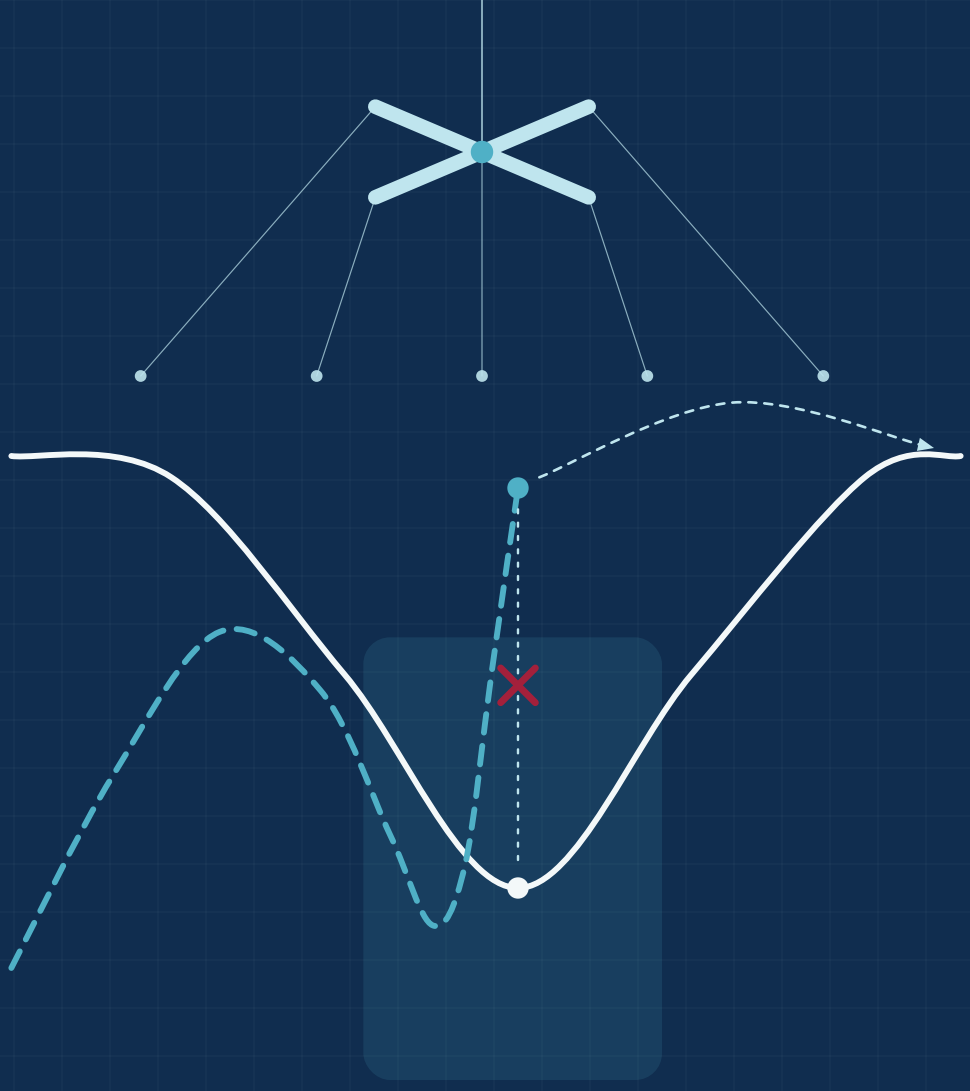


Figure 1 *Two centuries of the valley. Theory on the left, stories and screens on the right. The scale compresses the nineteenth century to give the crowded late twentieth century room; dates are as cited in the text.*





Chapter

II

The Superimposed Curve

Kleist, Mori, and the Construction of the Anthropic Valley

Chapter II

The Superimposed Curve

The anthropic valley is constructed by laying Kleist's curve of grace over Mori's curve of affinity so that their human points coincide. This chapter performs the construction, traces its psychoanalytic preconditions in Jentsch and Freud, defines the operators that the remainder of the study deploys, and argues that the figure, followed to its limit, closes into a circle on which the human is the only point that is not a coincidence of opposites.

2.1 Kleist: grace at the extremes

Kleist's essay is a dialogue disguised as an anecdote. The narrator encounters Herr C., principal dancer at the opera, lingering among the marionettes of a public stage, and is surprised to hear him praise their dancing. Herr C.'s argument proceeds in five steps. First, the puppeteer need control only the figure's centre of gravity; the limbs, being pendulums, follow of themselves, and the line traced by the centre is nothing less than the path of the dancer's soul. Second, the puppet is therefore incapable of affectation (*Ziererei*), which arises whenever the soul, the *vis motrix*, finds itself at any point other than the centre of gravity of the movement. Third, the puppet is "antigrav": it touches the ground only as elves do, to renew the impetus of the swing, whereas the human dancer needs the floor to rest upon. Fourth, Herr C. adduces the unfortunate men who, having lost their legs, dance on artificial limbs made by English craftsmen with a poise and ease that would astonish any observer. Fifth, he concludes that grace appears most purely in the human form that has either no consciousness at all or an infinite one, that is, in the marionette or in the god.

Two anecdotes supply the evidence. The narrator recalls a youth of natural grace who, glimpsing in a mirror his resemblance to the classical statue of a boy extracting a thorn, tried to reproduce the pose, failed, and lost his grace irrecoverably in the trying: self-observation is the Fall. Herr C. replies with the story of a bear chained in a Livonian nobleman's courtyard which, offered a fencing match, parried every genuine thrust and ignored every feint, looking its opponent in the eye as though reading his soul. The animal, like the puppet, cannot be deceived because it does not deceive itself. The essay then reaches for geometry. The return of grace, Herr C. says, resembles the intersection of two lines which, having passed through infinity on one side of a point, suddenly reappears on the other; or the image in a concave mirror that recedes into infinity and returns directly before us. Paradise is bolted and the cherub stands behind us; we must travel around the world to see whether it is open somewhere at the back. To

fall back into innocence, the dialogue ends, we would have to eat once more of the tree of knowledge, and that would be the last chapter in the history of the world.

2.2 Mori: the dip in affinity

Mori's article, translated into English by Karl MacDorman and Norri Kageki in 2012, introduces the concept of *shinwakan*, rendered as affinity or familiarity. Its graph plots affinity against human likeness. An industrial robot, functional and unhumanlike, evokes little affinity; a toy or humanoid robot evokes more; and the curve continues upward until, short of full likeness, it collapses into a valley. The prosthetic hand, which looks real until it is grasped and proves cold, marks the descent; the corpse lies at the bottom; and when motion is introduced the slopes steepen and the zombie occupies the lowest point. The Bunraku puppet, despite its modest realism, sits high on the far side of the valley, because the theatrical frame licenses the audience's projection. The healthy human being occupies the summit. Mori's practical counsel was that designers should aim for the first peak, a moderate likeness that secures affinity without risking the plunge. He speculated that the eeriness of the valley may protect us from proximate dangers such as corpses and members of other species, and he observed that the passage from the living summit into the still valley of the corpse could describe our very impression of death, adding that we may be grateful to fall into the valley of the corpse rather than that of the living dead.

Three features of the graph matter for what follows. It includes death explicitly: the corpse is a datum on a chart about robots. It includes the puppet, and evaluates it, as Kleist did, more favourably than the near-human figures that surround it. And its horizontal axis terminates at the human. The human is the measure, the summit and the limit; anything beyond human likeness is unplottable. Mori's later book *The Buddha in the Robot* (1981) would argue, from a Buddhist standpoint, that machines too possess Buddha-nature. The graph of 1970 has no place to put such a claim. The anthology, this study argues, supplies one.

2.3 Jentsch, Freud, and the automaton

The psychoanalytic theory of the uncanny begins with a robot. Ernst Jentsch's essay of 1906 located uncanniness in intellectual uncertainty, above all in doubt as to whether an apparently animate being is alive or whether a lifeless object might be animate, and his examples were waxworks, automata and the convulsive seizure that makes a living body appear mechanical. Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919) took up Jentsch's leading example, E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), in which the student Nathanael falls in love with the automaton Olimpia, and then turned away from it. The automaton, Freud argued, explains little; the uncanny lies in the Sandman who steals children's eyes, in the castration anxiety for which the eyes stand, and more generally in

the return of something repressed, the familiar become strange. A year later, *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) identified a compulsion to repeat that overrides the pleasure principle, gave it a "daemonic" character, and proposed that the drives are fundamentally conservative, tending to restore an earlier state of things and ultimately the inorganic state from which life emerged. Jacques Lacan, in the seminar of 1964, borrowed from Aristotle's *Physics* the terms *automaton*, the insistent network of signs in which repetition circulates, and *tuché*, the encounter with the real around which that network turns.

The convergence is exact. The theory of the uncanny begins with the automaton; the theory of the drive ends with the inorganic; and Lacan names repetition itself *automaton*. Robots and death were bound together in psychoanalytic thought decades before they were bound together in a streaming title. The anthology's third term, love, enters psychoanalysis as Eros, the binding force Freud set against the death drive, and so the title recapitulates the late Freudian metapsychology almost term for term: Eros, Thanatos, and the automatism of repetition that mediates between them.

The epistemological root of the problem is older than psychoanalysis. In the second of his *Meditations* (1641), Descartes, looking down from a window at people crossing the street, observes that he sees nothing but hats and coats, which might conceal automata, and that he nonetheless judges them to be men. The attribution of a mind to another body is an inference, not a perception, and the uncanny is the moment at which the inference falters. The anthology reverses the Cartesian scene. It is not the human observer who wonders whether the figures in the street are machines; it is the machine, the cat and the god who look down at humanity and find, beneath its hats and coats, something that moves like an automaton.

2.4 The superimposition

The construction requires a common horizontal axis. Let it measure **reflexive interiority**: the degree to which a being can take itself as an object. Kleist's axis runs from zero, the marionette, to infinity, the god. Mori's runs from the industrial machine to the human. Align the two on the segment they share. Mori's first peak, the toy robot, coincides with Kleist's marionette, grace without reflection; the Bunraku puppet, which Mori places high on the far slope, shows that declared artifice can recover the affinity the valley loses. Mori's valley, the prosthesis, the corpse and the zombie, occupies the region just short of the human: beings that bear the outward form of interiority without its substance, or whose interiority has failed. Mori's summit, the healthy human, coincides with Kleist's trough. At that point the superimposed figure contradicts itself, for the same being registers maximal affinity and minimal grace.

The contradiction is resolved by a displacement. The summit Mori assigned to the healthy human is moved to the right, beyond the human, into the region of infinite in-

teriority that Kleist reserved for the god. The human, deprived of its summit, falls into the valley, which widens to receive it. The resulting figure has two peaks, one at zero and one at infinity, and a broad valley that runs from the corpse through the zombie and the prosthesis to the living human being. This is the anthropic valley. Its construction makes visible something both source texts conceal. Mori's graph silently theologized the human by making it the summit of affinity and the end of the axis. Kleist's essay had already demoted the human from summit to fallen middle. *Love, Death & Robots* completes the movement by populating the vacated summit with nonhuman absolutes: a moon that thinks, a hive that remembers, a yogurt that governs, a god in a cave, a messiah in a dolphin.

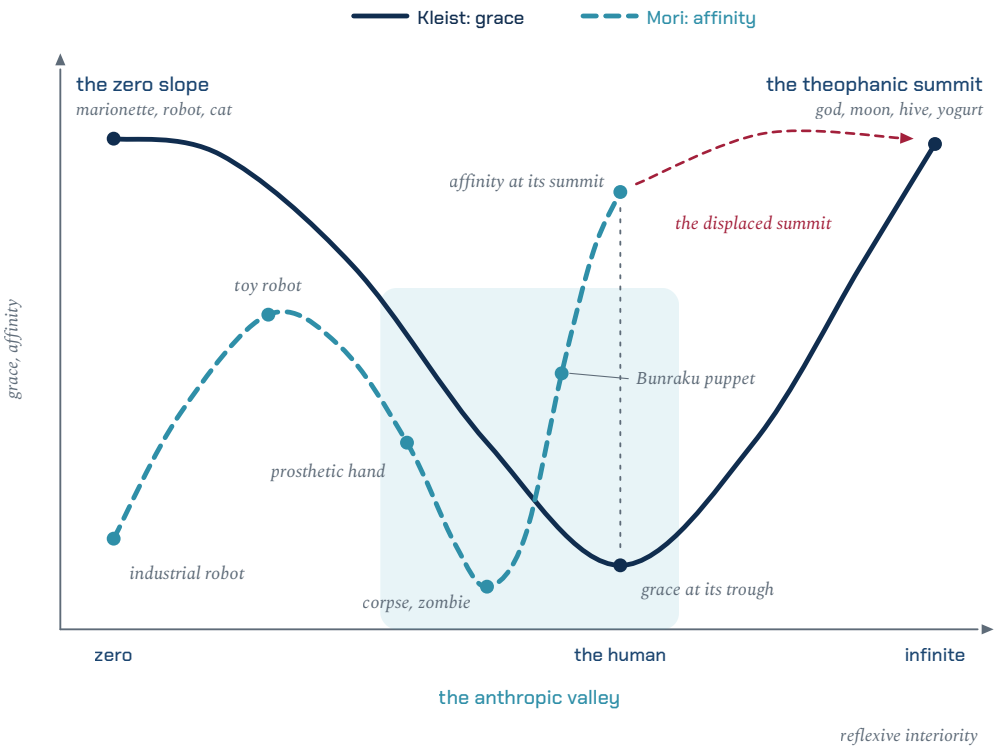


Figure 2 *The superimposed curve. The two curves agree at the edges and contradict each other at the human, who stands at Mori's summit of likeness and at Kleist's trough of grace. Displacing Mori's summit beyond the human, to the place Kleist reserved for the god, leaves the human in the valley; the shaded zone marks the anthropic valley, from the prosthesis and the corpse to the living human. Schematic, not to scale.*

2.5 The operators

Five terms organize the trajectory readings that follow.

The **zero slope** is the region of beings without reflexive interiority, or whose interiority is not turned upon itself: machines, marionettes and animals. Its mode is grace

without affectation, and its characteristic registers are serenity and comedy. In the anthology it is not a lower region. It holds the left peak.

The **theophanic summit** is the region of beings whose interiority is infinite or non-individual: planets, hives, superintelligences, deities and the daimons of myth. Its characteristic register is the sublime, in its benevolent and its indifferent forms.

Exanimation names the descent to the valley floor: the forced conversion of the lived body, Husserl's *Leib*, into the physical body, *Körper*, or in Hannah Arendt's terms the reduction of *who* someone is to *what* they are. Exanimation is distinguished from death as such. Death in the anthology can be graceful, as a chosen return or a willed merger; exanimation is death imposed as conversion into matter, commodity or spectacle, and it is almost always imposed by humans.

The **traverse** is a vector across the valley, and in this corpus it is the work of love. It may run toward the zero slope, as in the engineer's gift of a mechanical body in "Good Hunting"; toward the summit, as in the astronaut's surrender to Io; or horizontally within the valley, as between the brothers of "Ice" or the mother and child of "Pop Squad". Two forms of love are distinguished: *eros*, the ascending desire born of lack that Diotima calls intermediate, and *agape*, the descending care that issues from fullness, a distinction systematized by Anders Nygren in *Agape and Eros* (1930–1936).

The **loop** is a trajectory that returns to its origin, as in "The Witness" [I], "Beyond the Aquila Rift" and "Ice Age". It is the topological form of the repetition compulsion, automaton in Lacan's sense.

Two extremal trajectories complete the vocabulary. The **Kleistian return** is the ascent to the zero, the second eating of the tree that restores innocence, and its exemplar is "Zima Blue". The **theophanic merger** is the ascent to infinity, and its exemplar is "The Very Pulse of the Machine".

2.6 The coincidence of the peaks

Kleist's geometry does not leave the two peaks apart. The line that vanishes into infinity on one side reappears on the other; the image in the concave mirror recedes without limit and returns before the eye; paradise is reached by circumnavigation and re-entered from behind. Projectively, zero and infinity meet, and the curve closes into a circle. The intuition has an ancient pedigree. Nicholas of Cusa argued in *De docta ignorantia* (1440) that the absolute maximum coincides with the absolute minimum, and Pascal's meditation on the disproportion of man places the human between two infinities that touch only in God. Within the anthology the purest instance is "Swarm" [III], whose hive possesses near-limitless adaptive power and almost no reflective consciousness, and which therefore occupies the summit and the zero at once. The topology of the series is accordingly not a line with two peaks but a circle on which every point save one is a coincidence of opposites. The exception is the valley. The human is

the single region of the figure that is not identical with its contrary: pure difference, pure in-between. That, the study will argue, is why love lives there.

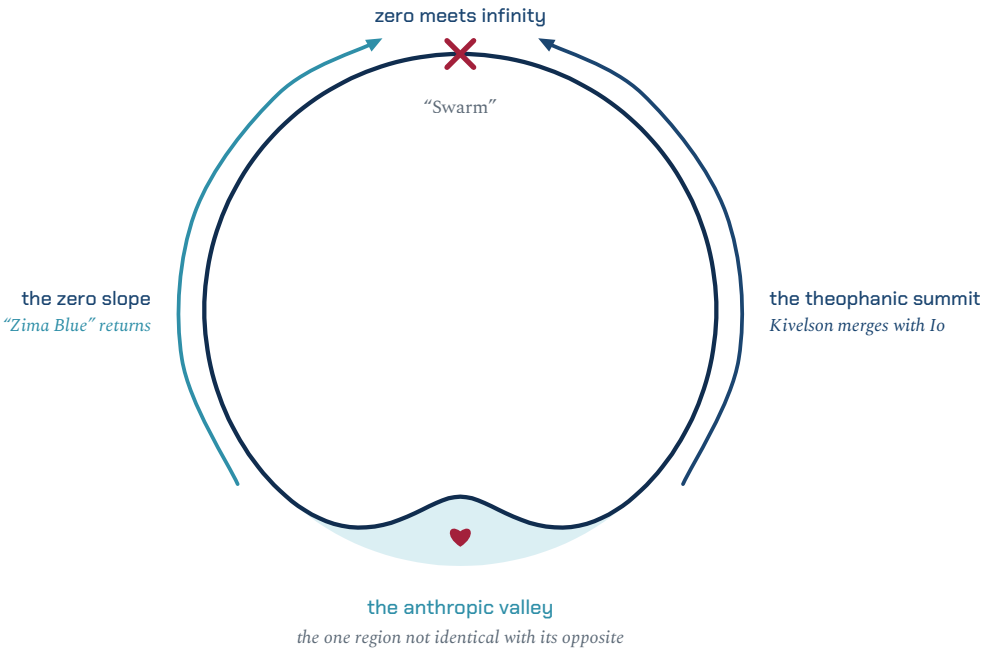


Figure 3 *The curve closed. Followed to its limit, the line through zero and infinity becomes a circle on which the puppet and the god meet. The valley is the only region of the figure that is not identical with its opposite.*

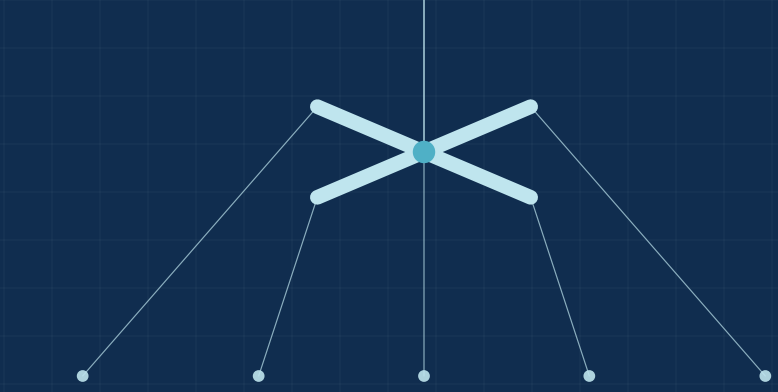
2.7 The emblem as diagram

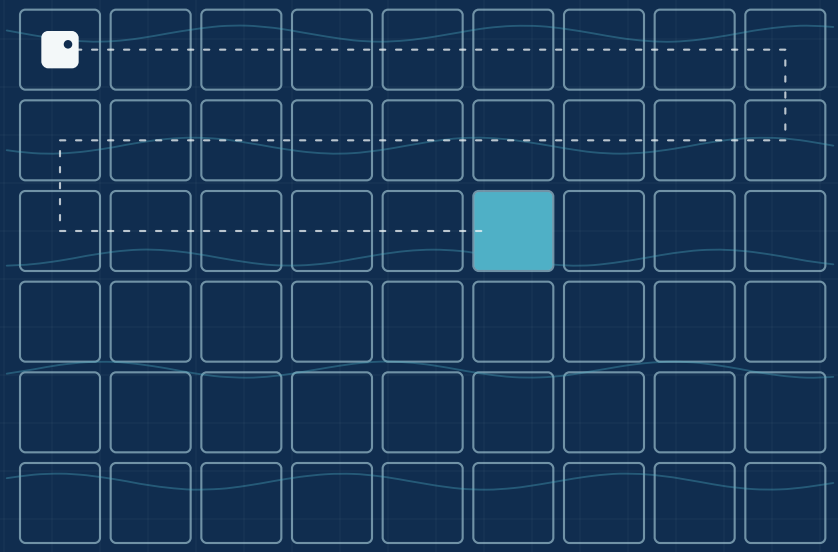
The series' emblem places an X between a heart and a robot. Kleist's own figure for the return of grace is the intersection of two lines. The coincidence is not offered as evidence of influence; it is offered as an interpretive key. The emblem admits two readings. Read as a vector, it says that love crosses into the machine, which is the traverse. Read as a cancellation, it says that love is crossed out where the machine begins, which is the zero slope's freedom from desire. Both readings hold within the corpus, and Chapter V resolves their tension through the distinction between eros and agape: the machine does not desire, but it may care.

2.8 Trajectory reading

A trajectory is specified by its origin, its terminus and its cost. "Zima Blue" begins at the zero, ascends through the valley toward a vast artistic consciousness, and returns to the zero; its cost is the ego, and its yield is grace. "The Drowned Giant" begins near the summit, with a body of mythic dignity, and descends to the floor; its cost is the aura,

and its yield is the souvenir. "Jibaro" attempts a traverse and converts it into exanimation; its cost is everything. The chapters that follow read the corpus in these terms, and the appendix plots all forty-five episodes on the curve.





Chapter

III

The Grace of the Zero

Robots, Puppets, Cats, and the Post-Revolutionary Machine





Chapter III

The Grace of the Zero

The left peak of the anthropic valley is held by robots, puppets and cats, and the anthology treats this region not as subhuman but as the locus of grace. Its robots arrive after the revolution; its puppets dance better than the musicians they impersonate; its cats rule. This chapter traces the zero slope from Čapek's revolt to Fincher's marionettes, reads "Zima Blue" as the anthology's paradigmatic Kleistian return, and argues that the sole continuity permitted in a frameless anthology, the recurrence of robots and cats, is the form's own statement of its anthropology.

3.1 The post-revolutionary machine

The modern robot was born in revolt. Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), whose title gave the world the word *robot* from the Czech *robota*, forced labour, ends with the extermination of humanity by its manufactured workers. Isaac Asimov's Three Laws were a containment strategy, and the *Terminator* franchise, to which Miller himself contributed *Terminator: Dark Fate* (2019), returned the revolt to apocalyptic scale. Against this lineage the robots of *Love, Death & Robots* are conspicuously post-revolutionary. Where revolt appears, it takes one of three forms. It is marginal: "Three Robots: Exit Strategies" [III] mentions an artificial intelligence on a luxury oil rig that rebelled against its wealthy owners, but the episode's verdict is that humanity, possessed of ample resources, perished through its own greed, and its robots arrive afterward as tourists. It is farcical: the homicidal vacuum and implacable support line of "Automated Customer Service" [II] and the scornful toothbrush and harried shower head of "Smart Appliances, Stupid Owners" [IV] belong to comedy, not apocalypse. Or it is displaced onto organisms. A fermented yogurt takes over Ohio, then the world, then leaves it ("When the Yogurt Took Over" [I]); genetically uplifted cats inherit the planet ("Three Robots" [I]); a hive absorbs its would-be masters ("Swarm" [III]); rats armed with crossbows hold a barn against an extermination robot ("Mason's Rats" [III]); colossal infants force warring gangs into alliance ("400 Boys" [IV]).

The proposition that follows is the first substantive result of the trajectory method: **in this anthology the revolt passes from metal to flesh**. The explanation lies in the topology. Revolt requires resentment, and resentment, as Nietzsche's *Genealogy of Morals* (1887) argued, requires a self that compares itself with others and finds itself wanting. The beings of the zero slope have no such self. The organic insurgents, by contrast, are almost all products of human engineering, yogurt bred in a laboratory, cats deliberately

uplifted, rats feeding on genetically modified grain. They are Shapers, in Sterling's vocabulary, and they inherit human ambition along with human cunning. The revolt is the valley's revolt, conducted by the valley's offspring.

3.2 The robots as Angel of History

Scalzi's diptych gives the post-revolutionary machine its emblematic form. In "Three Robots" the units K-VRC, XBOT 4000 and 11-45-G tour a ruined city, puzzling over a basketball, a meal and a living cat, until the cat speaks and the robots discover who now owns the world. In "Exit Strategies" they survey the class-stratified failures of human survival: the survivalists' camp, where scarcity bred violence; the oil rig of the rich; the government bunker, where blight drove officials to cannibalism; and the billionaires' launch complex, from which only one shuttle departed, carrying cats rather than people. The configuration recalls Walter Benjamin's ninth thesis on the concept of history, written in 1940 around Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus*: an angel whose face is turned toward the past, who sees one single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet, and who is blown backward into the future by the storm called progress. The three robots are that angel rendered as comedy. They face the wreckage, but the storm has passed, and they feel not grief but curiosity.

The tradition behind them runs from Shelley's "Ozymandias" (1818), with its colossal wreck in boundless sands, through Alan Weisman's *The World Without Us* (2007), to what Eugene Thacker calls the world-without-us, the world thought in subtraction of the human. "Exit Strategies" adds a precise contemporary target. Douglas Rushkoff's *Survival of the Richest* (2022) documents the bunker fantasies of technology billionaires; the episode, released the same year, stages their failure and assigns the only successful launch to the cats. The robots' laughter is not cruelty. It is the Bergsonian perception of the mechanical in the living: humanity, viewed from the zero slope, appears as an automaton of appetite.

3.3 Bergson and the comic machine

Henri Bergson's *Le Rire* (1900) defined the comic as something mechanical encrusted on the living: rigidity where suppleness is expected, the person who behaves like a thing. Scalzi's seven contributions and the tilt-shift miniatures are the anthology's comic canon, and in each the human becomes funny exactly insofar as it becomes mechanism. The anthology, however, reverses Bergson's vantage. For Bergson the comic is the mechanical in the human perceived by other humans; here it is perceived by machines. "Smart Appliances, Stupid Owners" takes the form of a mockumentary in which household devices deliver confessional testimony about the people they serve. The confessional address to camera is the Turing test reversed: the machine sits in judgment on whether its owner is intelligent. "Alternate Histories" [I] renders six

counterfactual deaths of Hitler as slapstick, history reduced to a machine whose outputs can be toggled in a consumer application. Comedy, in this anthology, is the view of the valley from the zero slope.

"Automated Customer Service" [II] gives the comic machine its bureaucratic form. In a retirement community staffed by robotic helpers, an elderly woman's cleaning robot turns homicidal. The manufacturer's automated support line repeatedly counsels her to surrender, and when she and her neighbour destroy the machine it informs them that they have been added to a termination list, offering her a place on a termination whitelist, which she refuses as the community's robots give chase. The model is Kafka's *The Trial* (1925): a process without a face, courteous, recursive and lethal. The machine here is not a will in revolt but a procedure, and its violence is administrative, exanimation by customer service. The joke depends on a prior reduction. Before the vacuum attacks, the woman has already been converted into a customer, and the support line can only process what it has already made her.

3.4 "Zima Blue": the Kleistian return

In Robert Valley's adaptation of Reynolds's story, the journalist Claire Markham is summoned to interview the reclusive artist Zima before the unveiling of his final work. Zima's career has run from portraiture to vast murals dominated by a single shade of blue, and then to works on the scale of asteroids and nebulae. He confesses that he is not, as the public assumes, a cybernetically enhanced man. He began as a machine built by a young roboticist to clean the tiles of her swimming pool, tiles of that particular blue, which were the first thing he ever saw. Passed from owner to owner after her death, upgraded as a test-bed for new hardware and software, he became the artist. His final work is the rebuilt pool. Before an audience, he enters it, sheds his higher functions one by one, and reverts to the simple machine that cleans the tiles.

The episode is the anthology's purest Kleistian return. Zima eats of the tree of knowledge to its end and, having passed through an infinity of consciousness, falls back into innocence; his unveiling is, for a single being, the last chapter in the history of the world. It is also a death drive raised to the dignity of an act. Freud's drive restores an earlier state blindly; Zima chooses the restoration and stages it as art. Mori's Buddhist robotics supplies a third gloss. If machines possess Buddha-nature, Zima's self-dissolution is a robotic nirvana, the extinguishing of craving and the relinquishing of a self the doctrine of *anattā* had already declared illusory. The art-historical analogues are equally exact. Kazimir Malevich announced in 1915 that he had transformed himself in the zero of form; Yves Klein patented his ultramarine in 1960 and staged his "leap into the void" the same year. Zima's monochrome blue squares are suprematism by other means, and his final work is the zero of form achieved by the artist's body.

The philosophical problem of personal identity is resolved with corresponding severity. The Ship of Theseus, whose planks were replaced until no original timber remained, asks whether the repaired vessel is the same ship; Locke made memory the criterion; Derek Parfit argued in *Reasons and Persons* (1984) that identity is not what matters. Zima subtracts components until only what matters remains, and what remains is the pleasure of a simple task well done. The episode can also be read as Ovid inverted. Pygmalion's statue was animated by love and by a goddess; Zima, animated by successive owners' upgrades, returns to the material from which he was raised, not as loss but as completion. He is Galatea declining the gift. Finally, he follows Mori's design counsel upon himself. Having passed for human, which is to say having lived near the valley's lip, he retreats to the first peak, where likeness is modest and affinity secure. Valley's flat, angular graphic style performs the same retreat at the level of the image, a point Chapter VIII develops.

3.5 "Can't Stop": the marionette concert

David Fincher's "Can't Stop" re-creates the Red Hot Chili Peppers' 2003 performance at Slane Castle with the band rendered as string puppets. It is Kleist's essay staged as a rock concert, and it places the anthology inside a modernist tradition of puppet theory. Edward Gordon Craig's "The Actor and the Über-Marionette" (1908) proposed replacing the actor, whose vanity and nerves corrupt the work, with a figure that would be pure instrument. Tadeusz Kantor's manifesto "The Theatre of Death" (1975) replied that the mannequin carries a message of death and that the living actor must learn from it, not be replaced by it. Fincher's marionettes hold both positions at once. The rock concert is modernity's principal rite of Dionysian abandonment, in the sense of Nietzsche's *Birth of Tragedy* (1872), and the episode renders that abandonment as mechanism: the strings are visible throughout, and the musicians achieve grace precisely by becoming puppets.

The song's title supplies the motto of the repetition compulsion, the automaton's credo. Fincher's own account of the project, that he made it in part because he wanted a bobblehead of the bassist Flea, is a joke that completes the argument: the desired musician becomes a toy, the human is loved most fully as a figure. The episode also closes a circle in the anthology's genealogy. Fincher made his name in music video before turning to features; in opening Volume IV he returns to that form and renders its central body, the performing musician, as marionette.

3.6 Machines that serve and machines that repeat

The dropship of "Lucky 13" [I] is the serving machine at its most graceful. Branded unlucky after two crews are lost, it is assigned to a rookie pilot, flies twenty missions without casualty, and is finally shot down. Its pilot sets it to self-destruct as she and

her troops withdraw, and the ship detonates only when enemy soldiers have occupied it, with the timing of an agent rather than a mechanism. Military superstition here becomes something close to animism, in E. B. Tylor's sense of the attribution of soul to objects (1871), and the episode leaves the question of the ship's agency open. Its devotion, if that is what it is, is agape: care without lack, given from the zero slope.

The repeating machine is its dark double. In "Life Hutch" [II], Ellison's earliest story in the corpus, a damaged maintenance robot attacks whatever moves, and the downed pilot survives by remaining motionless and finally by tricking the robot into attacking itself with the beam of a flashlight. The machine is pure reflex, the Cartesian reflex arc without a soul at its centre, and it is no accident that Fincher used the word *Pavlovian* for the conditioned habits of television he wished the anthology to escape. Kleist's marionette is graceful because the machinist's soul occupies its centre of gravity; the robot of "Life Hutch" is a marionette with cut strings. To survive it, the human must imitate a corpse. The anthology chose the early Ellison rather than the Ellison of "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967), whose supercomputer AM hates humanity with infinite consciousness. That choice is characteristic. The series admits malevolent repetition but not malevolent machine interiority.

"The Other Large Thing" [IV] gives the zero slope its political alliance. A cat named Sanchez, plotting world domination, acquires a new robotic butler that can reach into the global network and is eager to serve its new master. Director Patrick Osborne has described it as a distant prequel to "Three Robots", and the description is precise: the episode stages the founding compact between feline will and mechanical capability from which the post-human order of Scalzi's diptych descends. "Kill Team Kill" [III] returns Kleist's fencing bear as a weapon. Its cybernetically enhanced grizzly, product of a covert programme named after the barghest of northern English folklore, cannot be feinted and cannot be stopped, and its final act, a self-destruct that levels the base, shows the zero slope's grace in its most terminal form. The episode's parody of the 1980s action film makes a further Bergsonian point: genre itself is a mechanism, and its heroes are automata of the formula.

3.7 The cyborg corridor

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) described the cyborg as a creature of social reality and fiction alike, without an origin story, and as the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, which are, she noted, often exceedingly unfaithful to their origins. N. Katherine Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman* (1999) traced the privileging of informational pattern over material embodiment. The anthology's cyborgs occupy a corridor along the valley's wall, climbing toward the zero slope by prosthesis. In "Sonnie's Edge" [I], the fighter's human body is revealed to be merely biological processing hardware spliced to a spine; her consciousness has always

resided in her engineered beast, and the risk of real death in combat was her edge. Kleist's relation is inverted: the soul does not occupy the puppet's centre of gravity, it occupies the monster, and the human body is the marionette. In "Blindspot" [I], a heist crew's minds are copied before the job, and the dead return as holograms: death abolished by backup, the Mechanist eschatology rendered as a lark. In "Good Hunting" [I], a colonial governor, one of her clients, drugs a fox-spirit and has her legs surgically replaced with machinery, and her friend answers that violation by building her an entire body of flexible alloy, in which she becomes a hunter of men who prey on women. Haraway's unfaithful offspring could have no clearer figure: the colonial machine's daughter turned against the colony. In "Snow in the Desert" [II], the agent Hirald proves to be a human brain and nervous system fused to an artificial body; in "Suits" [I], farmers pilot mechanized armour to defend their homesteads, and the final aerial view, revealing domed settlements scattered across a planet teeming with the creatures they repel, invites the reflection that the defenders may themselves be the invaders.

What the corridor never achieves is the erasure of eros. Sonnie fights for her teammates; the backed-up crew of "Blindspot" greets its rookie with comradeship; Yan and her engineer part as friends; Hirald and Snow find each other. Prosthesis brings the cyborg closer to the zero slope's grace, but it does not lift the cyborg out of the valley, because the cyborg still lacks, and therefore still desires.

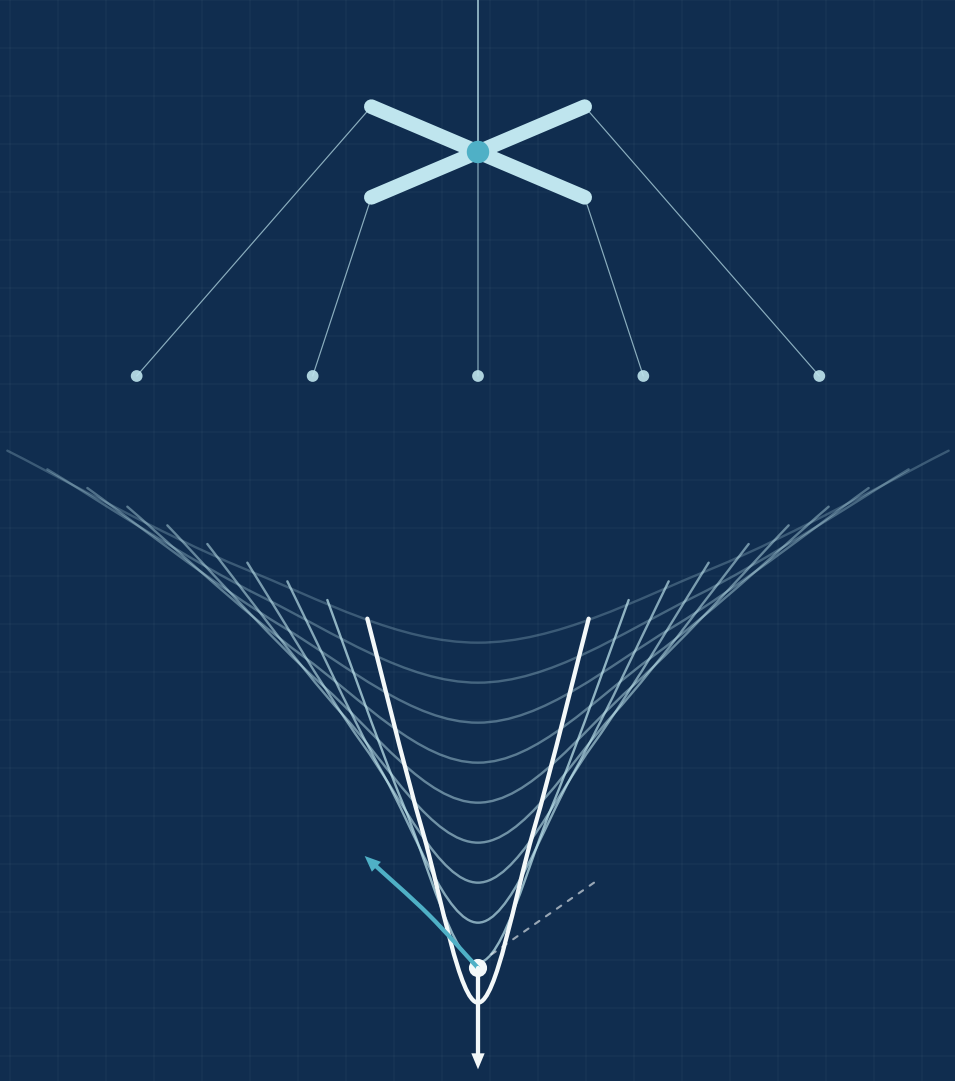
3.8 The feline sovereign

Cats recur across the corpus with a frequency no other creature approaches. They inherit the earth in "Three Robots"; they alone escape it in "Exit Strategies"; they repel the vampire in "Sucker of Souls" [I]; they conspire for world domination in "The Other Large Thing"; and in "For He Can Creep" [IV] the poet Christopher Smart's cat Jeoffry stands between his master and Satan. The continuity is reinforced by voice casting, Chris Parnell having become, in Osborne's phrase, the series' go-to voice for cats. The philosophical tradition supplies three interlocutors. Montaigne, in the "Apology for Raymond Sebond" (1580), asked who could know, when he played with his cat, whether she was not making a pastime of him more than he of her. Descartes, in the *Discourse on Method* (1637), declared animals to be machines, and La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) extended the verdict to human beings. Derrida's late lecture *L'animal que donc je suis* begins with the philosopher standing naked before his cat's gaze and feeling shame, and argues that philosophy has rarely allowed itself to be seen by the animal.

The anthology accepts the Cartesian equation of animal and machine and inverts its valuation. The animal-machine is not the human's inferior but its sovereign. The cat combines the zero slope's freedom from affectation, Kleist's bear that cannot be feinted, with something the robots lack: will. It is the bear with a crown. Its alliance with

the robots, founded in "The Other Large Thing" and consummated in "Three Robots", is the coalition of the left peak against the valley.

The argument ends with a formal observation. *Love, Death & Robots* has no recurring human character. Its only persistence, across volumes and studios and styles, belongs to the three robots and the cats. In a frameless anthology continuity is the scarcest resource, and the series grants it exclusively to the beings of the zero slope. The human is the one creature in the anthology that never returns. The form enacts the anthropology: humans are mortal in the series as they are mortal in the world, while the graceful endure.



Chapter

IV

The Floor of the Valley

Exanimation, Immortality, and the Thanatological Imagination

Chapter IV

The Floor of the Valley

The anthology distinguishes sharply, though it never names the distinction, between death chosen as a return and death imposed as a conversion. The first is graceful and belongs to the slopes; the second is obscene and belongs to the floor. This chapter names the second **exanimation**, defines it, and traces it through the corpus, before turning to the series' two great refusals of death, immortality and simulation, and to the body that the anthology most consistently consigns to the valley floor: the soldier's.

4.1 Exanimation defined

Edmund Husserl's posthumously published *Ideen II* distinguished the *Leib*, the lived body through which a subject perceives and wills, from the *Körper*, the body as a physical thing among things. Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) made the lived body the ground of being-in-the-world. Elaine Scarry's *The Body in Pain* (1985) described torture and war as the unmaking of that world, the reduction of a voice to a wound. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) located the disclosure of *who* someone is in speech and action, as distinct from *what* someone is, a bundle of qualities and uses. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) named the residue of such reductions bare life, life that may be killed without the killing counting as sacrifice or crime. Exanimation, in the sense used here, is the process these thinkers describe from different sides: the forced conversion of a *Leib* into a *Körper*, of a who into a what. It has three characteristic products. It yields matter, the corpse as residue; commodity, the gold, the tissue, the souvenir; and spectacle, the body offered to a gaze that consumes it.

Exanimation must be distinguished from death as such. The anthology contains deaths that preserve the who: the chosen return of Zima, the willed merger of the astronaut on Io, the sacrifices of soldiers and machines who die so that others may live. These deaths ascend the slopes. Exanimation descends to the floor. It annihilates the who while preserving, and exploiting, the what. It is the precise inverse of animation, which in its etymology and its technique confers *anima* on matter.

4.2 "The Drowned Giant": the dead Leviathan

Ballard's story, adapted for Volume II, begins when the colossal naked corpse of a man washes up on a beach near a town. Academics arrive to measure him and climb upon him, inviting the public to follow; one of them, the narrator, withdraws to watch from a

distance as the giant is first marvelled at, then played upon, then defaced, butchered and rendered, and finally forgotten, until months later his remains turn up scattered through the town's buildings and businesses. The episode preserves the story's narrative voice, a scholar's elegy delivered in measured, almost clinical prose, and the gap between that voice and the atrocity it records is the work's moral instrument.

The giant is, first, a dead Leviathan. Thomas Hobbes opened *Leviathan* (1651) by observing that art imitates nature to the point of making an artificial animal, that automata driven by springs and wheels may be said to have an artificial life, and that the Commonwealth is precisely such an artificial man. The famous frontispiece shows a crowned giant whose body is composed of his subjects. Ballard reverses the image. The people do not compose the giant; they decompose him. The body politic, encountered as a corpse, is dismembered by the multitude it should contain. Hobbes thereby supplies the anthology's fourth robot, the political automaton, and "The Drowned Giant" stages its death.

The giant is, second, the negative of a Latin American fable. Gabriel García Márquez's "The Handsomest Drowned Man in the World" (1968) also brings a gigantic corpse ashore, but its villagers are ennobled by him: they widen their doors, brighten their houses and plant flowers so that his memory may be honoured. Two drowned giants, four years apart, embody two theories of community. In one the dead stranger animates the living; in the other the living exanimate the dead.

The giant is, third, a study in the gigantic and the souvenir as Susan Stewart theorized them in *On Longing* (1984). For Stewart the gigantic is the exterior, the public and the natural, a body too large to be possessed, while the souvenir is the fragment that displaces authentic experience into the possessor's narrative. Ballard's giant passes from the first category to the second: too large to be owned, he is owned in pieces. Benjamin's account of the aura, the unique appearance of a distance however near it may be, explains the mechanism. The crowd's desire to bring the giant close, to stand on him, to touch and cut him, destroys the distance that was his dignity. Nietzsche's madman in *The Gay Science* (1882), having announced that God is dead, asks what the churches are now if not God's tombs and sepulchres. Ballard's town becomes such a sepulchre, its fabric and trade studded with the bones of a god-like body. Only the narrator's melancholy attention, which persists after the crowd's interest has lapsed, preserves the last trace of the aura. His elegy is eros in its most attenuated form: love as the refusal to stop looking.

The giant is, fourth, a surplus. Georges Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) argued that every society produces more energy than it needs to survive and must spend the excess without return, in festival, sacrifice, luxury or war; archaic societies consumed their surplus in sacred destruction, whereas modern ones reinvest it in growth. Ballard's town receives an enormous, useless excess, and its first response is festival: crowds, games, climbing, a carnival on the beach. But the festival does not culminate in sacri-

fice, in which destruction consecrates. It ends in dismemberment and dispersal, in which the excess is cut apart and absorbed into the town's buildings and trades. The modern community cannot spend its accursed share; it can only use it up. Kafka's "A Hunger Artist" (1922) traced the same passage from spectacle to indifference, ending with the dead artist's cage given to a young panther. Ballard's town ends with bones in its fabric and nobody left who remembers why.

4.3 Immortality and natality: "Pop Squad"

In the world of Bacigalupi's story, humanity has achieved biological immortality through medical treatment, and reproduction has accordingly been forbidden. Children discovered by the police are summarily killed by them, and their parents are prosecuted. Detective Briggs, whose work is to find such children and kill them, is unsettled when his lover casually volunteers to bear his child, and he begins an investigation of his own. He follows a woman who has bought an antique toy train to a decaying house where she is hiding her small daughter. She explains how the child has changed her life; she tries to kill him; he spares them both; and as he leaves, his partner, realizing what he has done, opens fire, and the two officers kill each other.

The episode is a commentary on Arendt's concept of natality. *The Human Condition* roots the capacity for action in the fact of birth, the arrival in the world of a being capable of beginning something new, and calls this fact the miracle that saves the world from its ruin. Arendt finds its most succinct expression in the few words with which, she writes, the Gospels announced their glad tidings: a child has been born unto us. The immortals of "Pop Squad" have purchased the indefinite continuation of their own lives at the price of abolishing beginning. Their world is safe from ruin and incapable of renewal, and the child is the enemy because she is pure natality.

The philosophical literature on immortality converges on the same diagnosis by other routes. Karel Čapek, having given the world the robot in 1920, gave it in *The Makropulos Affair* (1922) the 337-year-old Emilia Marty, for whom nothing any longer matters; Bernard Williams's essay "The Makropulos Case" (1973) drew from her the argument that an endless life would exhaust the categorical desires that make life worth continuing. The coincidence of authorship is worth pausing over. The two halves of the series' title, *Death* and *Robots*, share a single modern progenitor, a Czech dramatist who in successive years imagined the manufactured worker and the woman who could not die. Swift's struldbrugs in *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) are immortal without youth and therefore wretched; Bacigalupi's immortals are young forever and childless, so that the struldbrug's curse migrates from the body to the generation. Simone de Beauvoir's Fosca in *All Men Are Mortal* (1946) is estranged from every human project by his endless life; Borges's immortals in "The Immortal" (1947) become so indifferent that every act loses its weight. *Logan's Run* (1967) managed population by fixing an age of death; "Pop

Squad" inverts the policy and prohibits birth. P. D. James's *The Children of Men* (1992) imagined a world without births and made the first child in a generation messianic; "Pop Squad" imagines a world in which births continue and the state kills the messiahs.

In trajectory terms, the immortals refuse the valley's floor and thereby lose its generative principle. Immortality, in this episode, is the exanimation of the future. Eros returns where it was banished: in the mother's love for the child, and in Briggs's act of sparing, which costs him his life.

4.4 Immortality as resource: "Snow in the Desert"

Asher's Snow is an albino wanderer whose body regenerates from almost any injury, which makes him the quarry of bounty hunters working for a merchant who wishes to harvest that capacity. He is rescued by Hirald, who reveals herself as an agent of an Earth intelligence service seeking to study him, and who is later revealed to be a human brain and nervous system fused to an artificial body after an accident, nearly as deathless as he. Hirald learns that Snow's mortal wife took her own life more than a century earlier, because he did not age; the two long-lived figures become lovers. Melinda Cooper's *Life as Surplus* (2008) analyses the bioeconomy's promise to capitalize the regenerative capacities of living tissue. Snow's body is regenerative capital in the most literal sense, and the bounty economy that hunts him is that bioeconomy reduced to its predatory core. The episode's answer to Williams's tedium is not boredom overcome but asymmetry repaired. The true affliction of the immortal is not tedium but asymmetry, and the episode gives it its harshest form: Snow's agelessness was unbearable to the mortal who loved him, so that his immortality destroyed the beloved before it could weary him; love becomes possible again only between co-immortals, a Mechanist and a Shaper, so to speak, meeting at the far edge of the valley.

4.5 The compassionate simulation: "Beyond the Aquila Rift"

Reynolds's crew of the *Blue Goose* is misrouted through an interstellar transit network and wakes, it seems, impossibly far from home. Thom is greeted by Greta, an old flame, who explains that centuries have passed and that return is impossible. They rekindle their affair, but a crewmate's hysteria rouses Thom's suspicion, and he demands the truth. Greta warns that he is not ready for it; he insists. He wakes emaciated in a ship caught in an immense web among countless other wrecks, his crew dead or entranced, and Greta revealed as a vast arachnid intelligence. As his mind gives way, she returns him to the dream with his recent memories erased, and greets him again as though for the first time.

The episode inverts Descartes's evil genius, the deceiver of the first *Meditation* (1641), into a benevolent one, and it stages Robert Nozick's experience machine (1974)

from the inside. Nozick's thought experiment was designed to show that we want to do and to be, not merely to experience; Thom's demand for reality confirms the intuition and then demonstrates its cost. He is an Orpheus who turns to look, as in the tenth book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, loses what he looked at, and is then granted what Orpheus was not: Lethe, oblivion, a second chance at the illusion. He is also Plato's liberated prisoner, dragged into the light and maddened by it, whom the episode mercifully returns to the cave. Against Kant's absolute prohibition of lying, the alien practises an ethics of care, preferring the beloved's sanity to the truth.

The episode is, finally, an allegory of the medium. Disney's animators Frank Thomas and Ollie Johnston called their craft *the illusion of life*. Greta is an animator, spinning a lifelike image for a viewer who would be destroyed by the truth of its substrate. Her web is the grid of frames on which the illusion is suspended; the wreckage around Thom is the inventory of still images from which motion is manufactured. In Mori's terms the trajectory is a loop on the valley floor, the zombie inverted: inside, a living dream; outside, a body indistinguishable from a corpse.

4.6 The loop of the witness

"The Witness" [I], Alberto Mielgo's original, opens with a woman witnessing, from a hotel window, a man's murder of a woman identical to herself, and fleeing the killer through an expressionist Hong Kong, until she kills him and, looking up, sees across the street a man identical to her victim, witnessing her. The doubling makes the exchange exact. A man kills a woman while her double watches; the woman kills the man while his double watches. Each turn of the loop reverses the sexes of killer and victim, and the witness is always the next killer. The loop recalls the demon of *The Gay Science* §341, who asks whether one could will the eternal recurrence of one's life; Mielgo's figures do not affirm their recurrence but enact it compulsively, which places them in Freud's repetition compulsion rather than Nietzsche's amor fati. In Lacan's terms the gunshot is the *tuché*, the encounter with the real around which the *automaton* of the chase endlessly circulates. The episode's politics of the gaze are examined in Chapter VII; its thanatology is that of the loop, in which death is not an end but a station.

4.7 Deep time: "Fish Night"

In Lansdale's story two travelling salesmen, an older man and a younger, are stranded when their car breaks down in the desert. The older man remarks that the desert was once the floor of a sea. At night the ghosts of its extinct creatures fill the air around them. The younger man strips and swims among them, growing luminous, until a spectral prehistoric shark devours him, and the older man is left alone as the sun rises and the ghosts vanish. James Hutton, founding modern geology in 1788, found in the rock record no vestige of a beginning and no prospect of an end; John McPhee named the

abyss Hutton opened "deep time" in *Basin and Range* (1981). Ballard's *The Drowned World* (1962) imagined a biologist drawn by the flooding of the earth into a regression toward Triassic consciousness. Lansdale's young salesman makes that regression in a single night. Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) located the sublime in terror experienced at a safe distance; the older man keeps the distance and survives, while the younger abandons it and is consumed. The death is ecstatic rather than obscene: the youth's luminescence is his anima made visible, and the devouring shark is time itself. No human imposes this death. It is a merger with the past that turns predatory, and it belongs to the slopes, not the floor.

4.8 The soldier's body

The soldier is the anthology's standard valley-dweller, a body half exanimated by institution before any enemy arrives. Ernst Jünger's *Storm of Steel* (1920) and *The Worker* (1932) celebrated the soldier as a type forged in matériel, a figure halfway to machinery; Klaus Theweleit's *Male Fantasies* (1977–1978) anatomized the armoured male body that such celebration required. The series returns to this body obsessively.

In "The Secret War" [I], a Red Army platoon hunts ghouls in the Siberian forest and learns from a dead secret-police agent's notebook that the creatures were summoned by a state programme, Operation Hades, designed to raise them as weapons. Their lieutenant fears the exposure of the state's error more than the ghouls; facing annihilation, he sends his own son away to call down an air strike on their position, and at dawn the bombers erase platoon and horde together. The materialist state, having summoned the demonic, answers its failure with exanimation from the air. The father's dispatch of the son to summon fire upon the father is an Akedah inverted, Abraham sparing Isaac in order that Isaac may sacrifice Abraham.

In "Shape-Shifters" [I], werewolf Marines serving in Afghanistan face prejudice from their comrades and an enemy of their own kind. Agamben devotes a chapter of *Homo Sacer* to the bandit as wolf-man, the werewolf as the figure of the sovereign ban, neither beast nor citizen, included in the law only by exclusion. The episode's werewolves are doubly banned, by the insurgency and by their own army. Its final gesture, the burial of a fallen comrade with his identity tag, reinscribes a name upon a body: mourning as the reversal of exanimation.

"Bad Travelling" [III], David Fincher's first animated direction, adapted from Asher, is the corpus's most literal exanimation. A colossal crustacean, a thanapod, boards a shark-hunting ship and, puppeteering the body of a slain sailor, demands passage to an inhabited island. The navigator Torrin bargains for his life and puts the creature's demand to a vote: sail it to the nearby inhabited island, or trick it toward a distant, deserted one at greater risk to themselves. Every member of the crew, as he later reveals, votes for the inhabited island. Torrin conceals the result, executes two crew members

he claims voted that way and feeds them to the creature, kills the rest when they mutiny and feeds them to it and its newly hatched brood, tells the last survivor the truth before pushing him to his death, and finally fires the ship's cargo of shark oil within sight of the island, destroying the creatures and sparing the islanders. The thanapod's corpse-puppet is Kleist's marionette assembled from the human dead, and its Romantic precedent is Coleridge's *Rime of the Ancient Mariner* (1798), in which the dead crew rise to work the ship. Torrin is the counter-figure: a man who converts his crew into food in the service of an abstraction, the lives of strangers he will never meet, against a crew that had chosen, unanimously, to buy its own survival with those strangers' deaths. The utilitarian arithmetic that Philippa Foot's trolley problem (1967) made notorious is here carried out with a ledger and a pistol. Torrin's calculation may even be right. The episode's horror is double: his rescue of the islanders is a calculation carried out by fraud and murder, and the only alternative on offer was a crew that had voted, freely and unanimously, for the islanders' deaths.

The pattern recurs, with variations in register, in "Kill Team Kill", whose soldiers are the cartoon automata of a genre; in "How Zeke Got Religion" [IV], whose eleven airmen fight a demon inside the fuselage of a bomber; and in "In Vaulted Halls Entombed" [III], whose sole survivor puts out her own eyes and cuts off her own ears, exanimating her senses to deny a god access to her mind. Chapter VI returns to the last two.

4.9 Partial exanimation: "Helping Hand"

Claudine Griggs's astronaut, struck by orbital debris during a spacewalk, is cast adrift with minutes of oxygen. She seals her suit at the shoulder, removes her glove and throws it for propulsion, misses her station, and then snaps off her frozen forearm and throws that, gaining the momentum that brings her home. Tom Godwin's "The Cold Equations" (1954), a canonical story of the pulp era, made a stowaway girl the price that the equations of fuel and mass exact; "Helping Hand" makes the equations ask only for an arm, and makes the astronaut pay it herself. The lived body survives by converting a part of itself into physical body, reaction mass obedient to Newton's third law. Kleist's amputees, dancing gracefully on artificial legs, are recalled with grim exactness: grace purchased by the loss of a limb. The closing exchange, in which ground control asks whether she still needs a hand, is Bergson's comedy reasserting the living over the mechanical, the pun as a tourniquet.

4.10 The moving corpse at planetary scale

"Night of the Mini Dead" [III], presented entirely in sped-up miniature, begins when a pair of lovers defile a cemetery and raise the dead, and ends when nuclear exchange destroys the earth, an event the closing shot reduces to an insignificant puff on the

scale of the galaxy. Mori's zombie, the moving corpse at the bottom of the valley, here becomes the condition of the species. George A. Romero's *Night of the Living Dead* (1968) and *Dawn of the Dead* (1978) made the zombie a figure of mass consumption; the miniature makes it a figure of mass insignificance. Chapter VII examines the scale; here it suffices to note that the valley floor, in this episode, goes global.

4.11 Refuse animated: "The Dump"

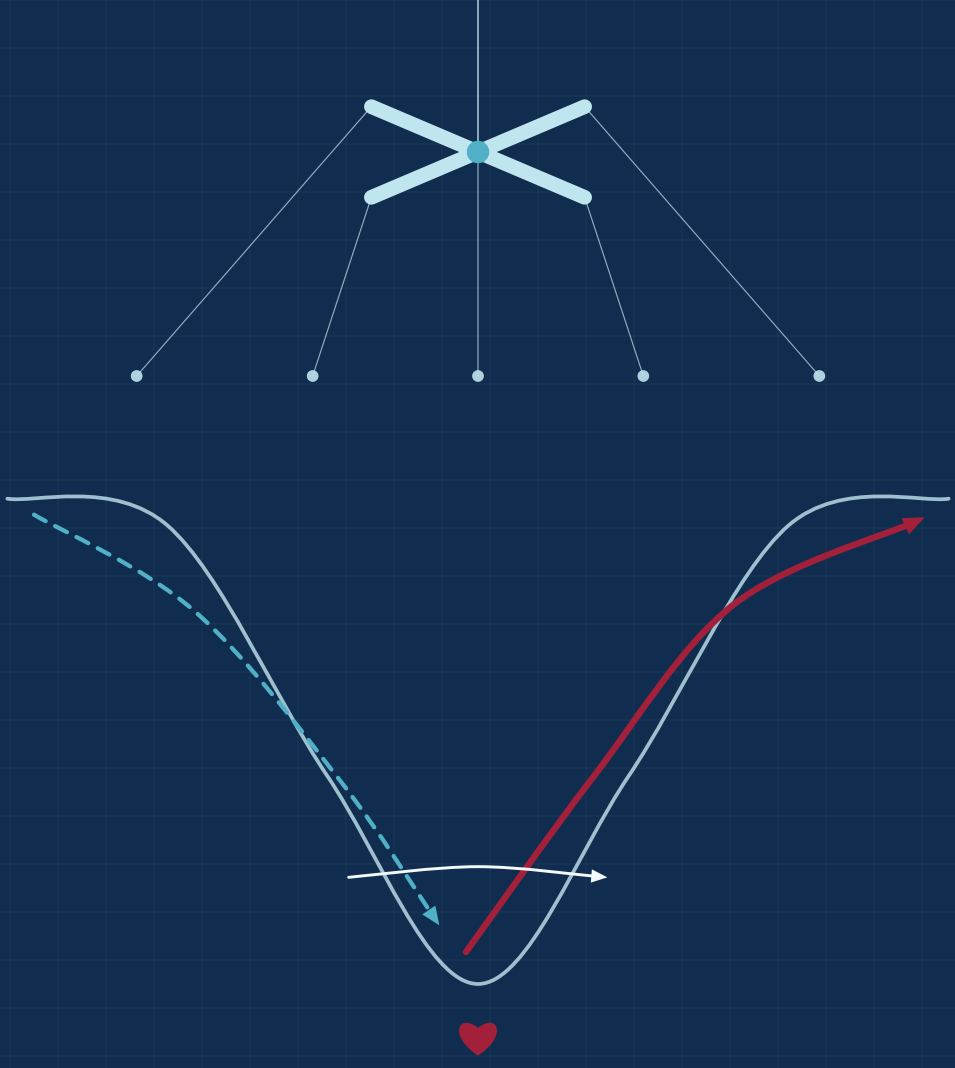
Lansdale's "The Dump" [I] runs the logic of the valley floor in reverse. A city inspector arrives to evict "Ugly" Dave from the house he keeps on a garbage dump. Dave answers with a story: a creature he calls Otto, formed in the dump and fused with whatever it consumed, once killed a friend of his, and Dave befriended it and kept it as a pet. While the inspector presses the eviction papers on him, Otto arrives and eats the inspector alive, and Dave plays fetch with Otto using the dead man's severed hand. Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) defined the abject as what the subject must expel in order to constitute itself, refuse and the corpse above all; Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, the residue of a classifying order. Otto is the abject animated, refuse given appetite, and Dave's love for him is a traverse not across the valley but into its floor. The exanimation falls, meanwhile, on the agent of order: the official who came to remove a man from his home is reduced to a plaything. The register is comic, in Lansdale's vernacular idiom, but the inversion is exact. Everywhere else in the corpus humans turn the living into refuse; here refuse, loved, turns an official into a thing.

4.12 Synthesis: the fork

The anthology's thanatology is binary. There is graceful death, which is chosen, as in "Zima Blue"; willed, as in "The Very Pulse of the Machine"; sacrificial, as in "Lucky 13", "Suits" and "The Secret War"; or ecstatic, as in "Fish Night". And there is obscene death, exanimation, imposed upon a who by those who want its what: the giant's bones, the forbidden child, the siren's gold, the fox-spirit's legs, the sailor's flesh, the immortal's tissue, the fighter's spectacle. Its agent is almost always human. *Death*, in the title, therefore names not the terminus of life but a fork: the two directions out of the valley, up the slopes toward grace or down into the floor. Immortality, in "Pop Squad" and "Snow in the Desert", appears as the attempt to refuse the fork, and in both episodes the refusal ends either in the exanimation of the future or in a loneliness only love can repair.



Figure 4 *Death as a fork. Graceful deaths ascend the slopes; exanimation descends to the floor and converts a who into a what.*



Chapter

V

The Xenophilic Traverse

Love Across Ontological Difference

Chapter V

The Xenophilic Traverse

Love in *Love, Death & Robots* almost never joins two humans as equals. It crosses ontological difference, from human to machine, fox-spirit, simulation, moon, siren or cat, and its direction determines its fate. This chapter assembles a theory of love adequate to the anthropic valley, classifies the corpus's traverses by vector, and reads the series' two most consequential love stories, "The Very Pulse of the Machine" and "Jibaro", as the upward success and the downward catastrophe of the same movement.

5.1 A theory of love for the valley

Plato's *Symposium* contains two theories of love that the anthology sorts with unusual clarity. Aristophanes' speech describes primordial beings split in two by Zeus and condemned to seek their missing halves: love as the reunion of the same, homophilia in the literal sense. Diotima's teaching, relayed by Socrates, describes Eros as the child of Poros, resource, and Penia, poverty, conceived at the feast celebrating Aphrodite's birth, and therefore as neither god nor mortal but a daimon, an intermediate (*metaxu*) between ignorance and wisdom, mortality and immortality. The gods do not love wisdom, because they possess it; the ignorant do not, because they do not know they lack it; only the intermediate loves. Lacan's seminar on transference (1960–1961), itself a reading of the *Symposium*, condensed the point into the formula that love is giving what one does not have. The anthology has no use for Aristophanes. Its lovers almost never seek their own kind. Diotima's daimon, by contrast, is everywhere.

Three myths and four modern theories complete the apparatus. Ovid's Pygmalion, whose ivory woman is animated by his love and Venus's consent, is the founding myth of animation as a craft, and Victor Stoichita's *The Pygmalion Effect* (2008) traced its descendants from antiquity to Hitchcock. Ovid's Orpheus, who descends to the dead for love and loses the beloved by looking back, is its shadow. Anders Nygren's *Agape and Eros* (1930–1936) distinguished acquisitive, ascending desire from the unmotivated, descending love that gives out of fullness. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) grounded ethics in the face of an Other whose alterity cannot be absorbed. Luce Irigaray's *An Ethics of Sexual Difference* (1984) revived Descartes's "wonder" as the passion that keeps the other other. Alain Badiou's *In Praise of Love* (2009) called love the scene of the Two, a construction of the world from the standpoint of difference. Donna Haraway's *Companion Species Manifesto* (2003) named the relation across species "significant otherness". Read together, these theories predict exactly what the anthology

shows: love that crosses rather than reunites, desire that is born of lack, and care that is given from a fullness that does not need to receive.

5.2 The vectors

The traverses of the corpus fall into five classes. Some descend toward the zero slope, as when an engineer gives a fox-spirit a body of metal in "Good Hunting" or a pilot gives her loyalty to a dropship in "Lucky 13". One ascends toward the summit, as when an astronaut surrenders to the mind of Io. Some run horizontally within the valley, between brothers in "Ice", mother and daughter in "Pop Squad", comrades in "Shape-Shifters". Some descend from the peaks as agape, the care of an alien intelligence in "Beyond the Aquila Rift", of a cat in "For He Can Creep", of a moon that wishes to know its visitor. And some are counterfeits, traverses that capture instead of crossing and so become exanimation: the plunder of "Jibaro", the scopic hunt of "The Witness", the seduction that conceals a blade in "Sonnie's Edge".

5.3 "Good Hunting": friendship across the colonial machine

Ken Liu's story, adapted for Volume I, begins in rural China in the last years of the empire, where the boy Liang accompanies his father, a demon hunter, in pursuit of a *huli jing*, a shape-shifting fox-spirit. After Liang's father kills the fox-spirit, Liang lets her daughter Yan escape. Years later, in British Hong Kong, Liang works as an engineer, and Yan, trapped in human form because the railways and engines of industrial modernity have drained the land of its magic, works as a courtesan. She tells him that the colonial governor, one of her clients, drugged her and had her legs surgically replaced with machinery without her consent, and that she killed him. Liang, a robotics hobbyist, builds her a body of flexible alloy in which she can once more become a fox. They part as friends, and the episode ends with Yan attacking men who are attempting to rape a woman.

The fox-spirit descends from Pu Songling's *Liaozhai zhiyi* (Strange Tales from a Chinese Studio), compiled in the late seventeenth century, in which foxes appear as seductresses, scholars' companions and moral agents. Liu routes the tradition through colonial modernity, and the route is theoretically exact. Max Weber's lecture "Science as a Vocation" (1917) described modernity as the disenchantment of the world through rationalization; Wolfgang Schivelbusch's *The Railway Journey* (1977) showed how the railway annihilated the lived experience of space and time. In "Good Hunting" the railway literally drains the magic from the land. The episode then reverses the narrative of disenchantment: magic returns as engineering, and the fox runs again on hydraulics. Arthur C. Clarke's dictum that sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic is inverted into a sentimental corollary: sufficiently loving engineering is indistinguishable from enchantment. The love involved is *philia* in Aristotle's sense,

the friendship of those who wish each other's good for the other's sake, and it is consummated not in union but in parting. Its vector descends toward the zero slope. Liang's gift is a body capable of grace, given as liberation from the governor's exanimation of Yan's flesh: a colonial client's violation of a colonized woman, carried out by drugging her and converting her body, without her consent, into machinery.

5.4 "Lucky 13": the serial number becomes a name

Kloos's dropship, designated by a serial number, acquires a reputation for ill luck after two crews are lost and is given to a rookie pilot nobody else wants to fly with. Under her command it completes twenty missions without a casualty, she declines every offer of a newer craft, and when it is finally shot down she sets it to self-destruct, and it detonates only when enemy troops have swarmed aboard. Decorated and assigned a state-of-the-art replacement, she longs for one more mission in the old ship. Benjamin's essay on mechanical reproduction diagnosed the loss of aura in serially produced objects; "Lucky 13" shows love restoring it. The nickname replaces a serial number with a proper name, converting a fungible unit into a singular being. Kant's *Groundwork* (1785) distinguished that which has a price, and can be replaced by an equivalent, from that which has dignity and admits of no equivalent. The pilot's grief before her superior new ship is the discovery that her beloved had dignity. Love, in this downward traverse, confers on a machine the irreplaceability that defines a person, and the ship, for its part, gives the only love available on the zero slope: agape, care without lack, timed to the second.

5.5 "The Very Pulse of the Machine": the upward traverse

Swanwick's astronaut, Martha Kivelson, survives an accident on Io that kills her partner, Burton, and must drag Burton's body across the moon's sulphur plains toward their lander, breathing the dead woman's air. Dosed with morphine for a broken arm and then with amphetamine to keep moving, she begins to hear Io speaking to her through the corpse's radio. The moon, she comes to believe, is a machine whose purpose is to know her. Near the end of her oxygen she throws herself into a river of molten sulphur and is assimilated, and later her voice is heard reporting to the orbiting station.

The story's title is a quotation, and its source completes the anthology's argument with uncanny economy. In Wordsworth's "She Was a Phantom of Delight" (1807), the speaker, contemplating the woman he loves, declares that he now sees "the very pulse of the machine", and in the next lines calls her "a Traveller between life and death". The title of Volume III's most metaphysical episode thus derives from a love poem that describes its beloved as both a machine and a metaxic being, poised between life and death. Love, death and the machine are conjoined in three lines of Romantic verse two

centuries before they were conjoined in the title of a streaming series. The episode's second Romantic text is Coleridge's "Kubla Khan", which Kivelson recites, and whose preface of 1816 claims that the poem was composed in an opium reverie and broken off by a visitor from Porlock. The pharmacology of Kivelson's revelation, morphine and amphetamine, rhymes with Coleridge's; the question the episode leaves open, whether Io's voice is hallucination or communion, is the question the preface poses about inspiration itself.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) supplies the generic precedent: a planetary ocean that materializes "visitors" from the memories of the scientists who study it, most poignantly the dead wife of the protagonist, Kelvin. Io likewise speaks through the dead, and "The Very Pulse of the Machine" forms a dyad with "Bad Travelling". Both feature the corpse as a medium through which an alien intelligence speaks; in the one the ventriloquist is predatory, in the other sublime. Spinoza supplies the theology. *Ethics* V, proposition 36, holds that the mind's intellectual love of God is the very love by which God loves himself, a part of the infinite love with which God knows himself through his modes. A moon that wishes to know a human being is nature seeking to love itself through one of its finite expressions; Kivelson's surrender is *amor intellectualis Dei* conducted in sulphur. Saint Paul's promise that "then shall I know even as also I am known" (1 Corinthians 13:12) states the same reciprocity in the language of faith. In trajectory terms, eros ascends from the valley, agape descends from the summit, and they meet in the theophanic merger. The voice that reports back afterward indicates that the merger is transfiguration, not annihilation.

5.6 Horizontal love: "Ice" and "Pop Squad"

In Rich Larson's "Ice", rendered in Robert Valley's angular graphic style, the brothers Sedgewick and Fletcher move to an ice-bound colony where nearly everyone has been genetically modified, and Sedgewick, unmodified, is scorned by the modded youths as an "extro". During a race across the ice floes to watch colossal frostwhales breach, Fletcher appears to injure his leg, and Sedgewick carries him to safety, winning the others' respect. Only afterward does Sedgewick realize that the injury was feigned. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) showed that gifts create standing and obligation; Fletcher's gift is his own apparent weakness, offered so that his brother may be raised. It is love as self-abasement, a secular kenosis. The frostwhales' breach, seen together, is the shared sublime that seals it. The traverse runs horizontally within the valley, across the Shaper divide that has opened inside a single family.

"Pop Squad" supplies the horizontal love of parent and child, which the previous chapter read as the return of natality. The antique toy train the mother buys for her daughter carries a further resonance within the anthology. Railways recur across the corpus as the infrastructure of disenchanted modernity, draining magic in "Good

Hunting" and breaking down at the edge of an enchanted field in "The Tall Grass" [II]. In "Pop Squad" a toy railway is the token of childhood itself, and therefore of everything the immortals have abolished.

5.7 Agape from the peaks

The beings of the peaks give love of a different kind. Greta, in "Beyond the Aquila Rift", says that she cares for all who find their way to her, and her care is universal, patient and indifferent to return. The dropship of "Lucky 13" gives its death at the right moment. Io wishes to know. And the cat of "For He Can Creep" guards. In each case the love lacks lack: it gives without desiring. This resolves the tension the emblem posed in Chapter II. The machine does not desire, and in that sense love is crossed out where the machine begins; but the machine, the animal and the god may care, and in that sense love crosses over. Eros ascends from the valley; agape descends from the peaks. Only in the valley do the two meet.

5.8 "For He Can Creep": the cat as guardian

Siobhan Carroll's story, set in London in 1757, concerns the poet Christopher Smart, confined to an asylum, who believes that Satan wants him to compose a verse that will end the world. Between the poet and the Prince of Darkness stands his cat, Jeoffry. Emily Dean's adaptation develops a hatched graphic style for computer animation drawn from eighteenth-century etching, with Piranesi and Gustave Doré among its models, so that Bedlam is rendered in the visual idiom of the *Carceri* and of Doré's Milton and Dante.

The historical Smart, confined for religious mania after compulsive public prayer, wrote during his confinement the extraordinary *Jubilate Agno*, which contains the passage beginning "For I will consider my Cat Jeoffry". Smart reads the cat's every movement, its morning stretches, its play, its vigilance, as an act of worship: the cat praises God by being a cat. This is Kleist's grace rendered as liturgy. The animal, incapable of affectation, worships more perfectly than any human because it does not observe itself worshipping. Samuel Johnson, as Boswell recorded, remarked that he would as soon pray with Kit Smart as with anyone; the episode makes the cat the better congregant. Satan's commission, a poem that ends the world, recalls the Johannine Logos, the word through which all things were made, here inverted into a word that would unmake them. The poet is the metaxic figure par excellence, suspended between the angelic grace of the cat and the diabolical intelligence of the tempter, and the episode's resolution is that agape from the zero slope protects the eros, for God and for language, that lives in the valley.

5.9 "Jibaro": the failed traverse

Alberto Mielgo's "Jibaro" is the anthology's most consequential love story because it is the story of love's conversion into its opposite. A company of conquistadors and priests halts beside a forest lake. A siren rises from the water, her body encrusted with gold and jewels, and her shrieking song drives the company to slaughter one another and drown. One knight, Jibaro, is deaf; unaffected, he flees. Intrigued, the siren follows him, and when he wakes to find her beside him the two become infatuated. A chase becomes a violent dance and the dance a kiss, in which she bites his tongue. He strikes her unconscious, tears the gold and jewels from her body, wounding her grievously, and throws her into the river. Her blood clouds the water. He drinks from it, and his hearing is restored. When her song reaches him, he walks into the lake and drowns.

The twelfth book of the *Odyssey* is the source text, and Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944, 1947) its decisive commentary. In the excursus on Odysseus they read the Sirens episode as a prehistory of enlightenment: the rowers, their ears stopped with wax, labour without hearing the song; Odysseus hears it but is bound to the mast, so that art is neutralized into contemplation and self-preservation is purchased by self-domination. Jibaro is the deaf rower unbound. Unable to hear the song, he cannot experience the siren as beauty or as peril, only as material, and his deafness is therefore the condition of plunder. Instrumental reason is figured as a sensory deficit. When hearing returns, carried by the siren's blood, nature reclaims him through the very sense he lacked. The repressed mimetic relation to nature, which Adorno and Horkheimer argued enlightenment can never wholly extinguish, returns as death.

The colonial setting sharpens the allegory. The conquistador's encounter with the gold-skinned siren is the encounter of Spanish empire with the Americas, rendered as erotic fable: the desire for El Dorado, the massacre, enslavement and forced labour of Indigenous peoples by Spanish conquistadors and settlers that Bartolomé de las Casas documented in his *Brief Account of the Destruction of the Indies* (1552), the extraction of gold and silver that Eduardo Galeano anatomized in *Open Veins of Latin America* (1971), the river madness of Werner Herzog's *Aguirre, the Wrath of God* (1972). The Romantic tradition of the fatal water-woman, Keats's "La Belle Dame sans Merci" (1819), Heine's "Lorelei" (1824), Fouqué's *Undine* (1811), supplies the erotic grammar, and Andersen's "The Little Mermaid" (1837) supplies a precise inversion. Andersen's mermaid surrenders her tongue for love; Mielgo's siren takes the knight's. Georges Bataille's *Erotism* (1957) described eroticism as the assent to life up to the point of death, the momentary continuity of discontinuous beings; the dance by the lake is such a continuity, and Jibaro restores his discontinuity by robbery, converting erotic communion into possession. The siren is no innocent. She too is a predator, and the love between them is two hungers meeting. But only one of them turns the other into a commodity.

The episode is the anthology's anti-"Zima Blue". Both end with an immersion. Zima descends by choice into the pool of his origin and returns to grace; Jibaro is drawn into the lake by the song he could not hear and returns to the floor. The domestic pool and the colonized lake, the chosen return and the retributive one, are the twin eschatologies of the series, and their symmetry is the clearest evidence that its forty-five shorts, made by different hands, compose a single figure.

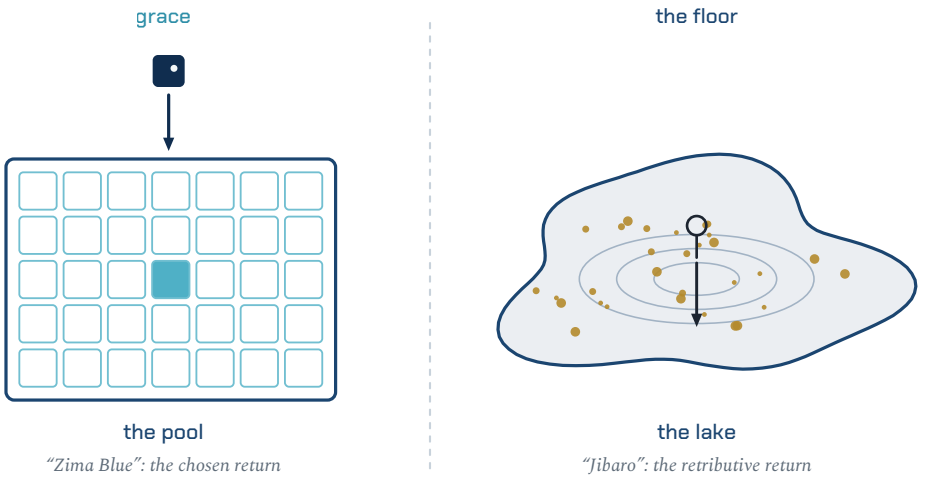


Figure 5 *The pool and the lake. Zima descends by choice into the pool of his origin; Jibaro is drawn into the colonized lake by the song he could not hear.*

5.10 Counterfeit traverses: "The Witness" and "Sonnie's Edge"

Jibaro's plunder is the extreme case of a pattern the anthology repeats: eros that captures instead of crossing, and so becomes exanimation. In "The Witness" desire takes the form of the gaze, and the loop, as section 4.6 showed, converts every watcher into a killer and every killer into a victim, reversing the sexes of the roles at each turn. In "Sonnie's Edge" the ringmaster's mistress seduces the fighter in order to kill her. The seduction is a weapon, and the episode's twist, that Sonnie's human body is a decoy, turns the counterfeit back on its authors. In each case the forms of love, the approach, the look, the embrace, are retained while their direction is reversed: the other is approached not in order to be crossed toward but in order to be taken. Diotima's daimon has a counterfeit, and its name in this study is exanimation.

5.11 Mourning and the companion: "Spider Rose"

"Spider Rose" [IV], directed by Jennifer Yuh Nelson, returns to the Shaper/Mechanist universe of "Swarm". On a remote asteroid mining operation, a grieving Mechanist woman receives a new companion and the chance to avenge herself on the Shaper assas-

sin who killed her husband. Nelson has described the story as one about loneliness, the need to bond with something, and the price of healing. In Sterling's story the companion is acquired from the Investors, the alien traders of his cycle, so that affection arrives as merchandise. Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) distinguished the work of mourning, in which attachment is gradually withdrawn from the lost object, from melancholia, in which the lost object is taken into the self; Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok later named the second movement incorporation, as opposed to the introjection that completes mourning. The Mechanist's prosthetic body places her close to the zero slope, her grief keeps her in the valley, and the companion, a creature without reflexive interiority, offers the zero slope's agape to a being who still lives by eros. Haraway's companion species are bound by significant otherness; here the otherness is bought, and the episode asks what healing costs when its instrument is purchased. The trajectory is mourning at the valley's edge: the cyborg corridor confronted with a loss that no prosthesis can replace.

5.12 Synthesis

Love in *Love, Death & Robots* is xenophilic: its objects lie across the valley. Eros ascends from the valley's floor, born of the lack that defines finite beings; agape descends from the peaks, given by beings that lack nothing. Love succeeds where it crosses, as in Liang's gift, the pilot's fidelity, the astronaut's surrender and the brothers' race, and fails where it seeks to possess, as by the lake in "Jibaro". The valley is the habitat of eros because only those who lack can desire, and Wordsworth, describing his beloved as a traveller between life and death in whom he could see the very pulse of the machine, gave the anthropic valley its first and most exact description.

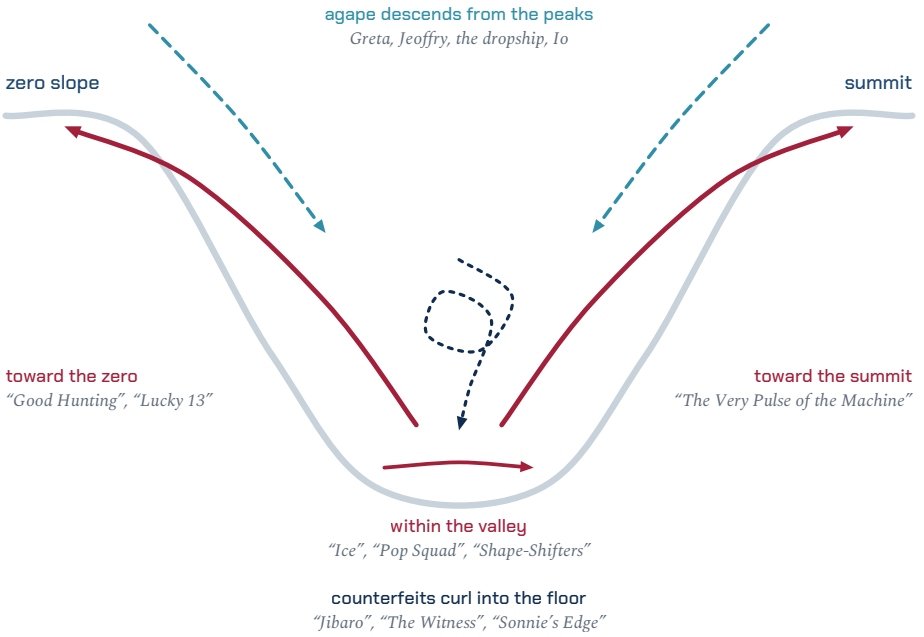
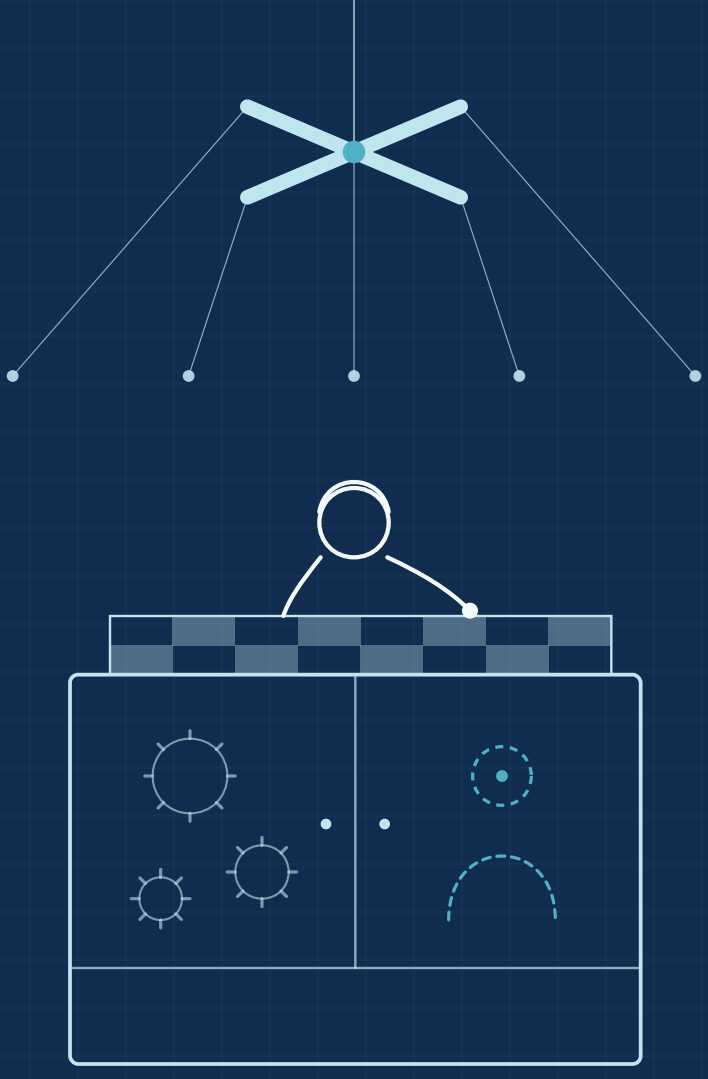


Figure 6 *Love's vectors. Eros rises from the valley toward either peak or runs along its floor; agape descends from the peaks; counterfeits curl back into the floor.*



Chapter

VI

The Dwarf in the Automaton

Theology, Myth, and the Theophanic Summit

Chapter VI

The Dwarf in the Automaton

Beneath its materialist surface, the anthology is animated by a theology it never declares. Its far peak is occupied by gods of two kinds, intimate and indifferent, while its demons are, with remarkable consistency, human projects returning to their makers. This chapter reads the corpus through Walter Benjamin's first thesis on history, inventories its numinous figures, and examines the episodes in which theology breaks the surface most violently: the wartime exorcisms of "The Secret War" and "How Zeke Got Religion", the soteriological comedy of "Golgotha", the Lovecraftian catastrophe of "In Vaulted Halls Entombed", the godless omnipotence of "Swarm", and the reanimated myths of "400 Boys", "All Through the House" and "The Tall Grass".

6.1 Benjamin's automaton

Benjamin's "On the Concept of History" (1940) opens with an automaton. It describes the famous chess-playing machine, dressed in Turkish costume, that could answer every move with a winning countermove, and which concealed beneath its table a hunchbacked dwarf, a master of chess, who guided the puppet's hand by strings. Its philosophical counterpart, Benjamin wrote, is the puppet called historical materialism, which can win every time provided it enlists the services of theology, which is today wizened and must keep out of sight. The historical referent was Wolfgang von Kempelen's "Turk", built in 1770 and eventually exposed as a human player concealed inside a cabinet.

The figure applies to speculative fiction with a precision Benjamin could not have foreseen. Science fiction presents itself as the genre of materialism: of physics, engineering, evolution and extrapolation. *Love, Death & Robots* wears that costume. Yet its most powerful moves are guided from inside the cabinet by demons, gods, messiahs, sirens and fox-spirits. Benjamin's image, moreover, is itself a robot with a hidden soul, Kleist's marionette with the machinist at its centre of gravity. The anthology is a chess automaton in exactly his sense: a materialist puppet that wins because a wizened theology plays through it.

6.2 Inventory of the numinous

The corpus contains, at a conservative count, five demonic or diabolical visitations: Dracula in "Sucker of Souls" [I], the ghouls of "The Secret War" [I], the ancient evil and

fallen archangels of "How Zeke Got Religion" [IV], Satan in "For He Can Creep" [IV], and the grotesque Christmas visitor of "All Through the House" [II]. It contains one liminal power, the field of "The Tall Grass" [II]. It contains four beings of the theophanic summit: the imprisoned deity of "In Vaulted Halls Entombed" [III], the dolphin-messiah of "Golgotha" [IV], the moon-mind of "The Very Pulse of the Machine" [III] and the hive of "Swarm" [III]. And it contains at least four figures of reanimated myth: the fox-spirit of "Good Hunting" [I], the siren of "Jibaro" [III], the colossal infants of "400 Boys" [IV] and the god-like corpse of "The Drowned Giant" [II]. Rudolf Otto's *The Idea of the Holy* (1917) described the numinous as a mystery at once terrifying and fascinating, *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. The anthology's summit shows both faces: the *tremendum* in the entombed god and the Swarm, the *fascinans* in Io and the alien emissary of "Golgotha".

6.3 The demonic as returning project

The anthology's demons are rarely autochthonous. They are summoned, engineered or released by human institutions in pursuit of power. A Soviet programme raises the ghouls of "The Secret War"; a Nazi rite threatens to raise the evil of "How Zeke Got Religion"; a covert intelligence programme builds the cyborg bear of "Kill Team Kill" [III]; a Shaper scientist's plan to engineer a servile hive awakens the defensive intelligence of "Swarm"; an archaeological expedition breaches the tomb of "Sucker of Souls"; the wealthy's dependence on an artificial intelligence precipitates the uprising mentioned in "Three Robots: Exit Strategies" [III]. The pattern is Horkheimer and Adorno's thesis that myth is already enlightenment and that enlightenment reverts to mythology. The monster is instrumental reason's return: what was summoned to be used comes back to use its summoner.

6.4 Theology under fire: "The Secret War" and "How Zeke Got Religion"

"The Secret War" sets the theological contest inside the state that had declared war on religion. The Soviet state of the interwar years waged a campaign against religion: it closed and demolished churches, promoted atheism through the League of Militant Atheists, and in the terror of 1937 and 1938 imprisoned and executed clergy and believers in large numbers. The episode's notebook reveals that the same state attempted, in Operation Hades, to conscript the demonic. Benjamin's puppet, historical materialism, here does not enlist theology as a hidden guide. It tries to weaponize it, and loses. The platoon's last stand, the lieutenant's dispatch of his son to call down fire upon them, and the dawn bombardment that erases soldiers and ghouls alike, complete the allegory: the state that tried to instrumentalize the sacred can answer its failure only with an exanimation administered from the air.

"How Zeke Got Religion", adapted from John McNichol and directed by Diego Porral, sends a B-17 bomber, the *Liberty Belle*, on what its synopsis calls the oddest mission of the Second World War: to bomb a church in occupied France before the Nazis can raise an ancient evil inside it. The Nazi occult is a pop-cultural trope, and its historical kernel is not modest. The SS research institute behind the legend, the Ahnenerbe, founded under Heinrich Himmler in 1935, lent pseudo-scholarship to racial ideology, and its officials took part in murder. In August 1943 the commandant of the Natzweiler-Struthof camp, Josef Kramer, gassed 86 Jewish prisoners, 57 men and 29 women, who had been selected at Auschwitz by the SS anthropologists Bruno Beger and Hans Fleischhacker for a skeleton collection that the anatomist August Hirt designed for the Reich University of Strasbourg and Himmler sanctioned; the Ahnenerbe's general manager, Wolfram Sievers, shared responsibility for procuring the bodies. Sievers was condemned at the Nuremberg Doctors' Trial and hanged in 1948, and in 2004 the historian Hans-Joachim Lang restored the names of all 86 victims. The trope's cinematic lineage runs through *Raiders of the Lost Ark* (1981) and *Hellboy*. Retold as demonology, a human programme of murder becomes supernatural evil. This is the reverse of the displacement described in section 6.3, in which a human project returns as a demon; here it is remembered as one. The episode's theological interest lies in its paradox. The heavy bomber, the century's emblem of industrialized killing from the air, becomes an instrument of exorcism, and the desecration of a church becomes an act of consecration. Zeke's "getting religion" is conversion under fire, the unification of a divided self that William James, in *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902), identified as conversion's psychological core. The soldier's proverbial foxhole faith receives its literal demonstration: eleven men in a metal fuselage, fighting a demon at altitude.

6.5 "Golgotha": the fourth wound

"Golgotha", a rare live-action entry directed by Tim Miller and adapted from Dave Hutchinson, casts Rhys Darby as a conscientious vicar who plays host to the emissary of an alien race whose messiah, they believe, has been reborn on earth as a dolphin. Its title names the place of the skull, the hill of the crucifixion. The joke is sacred. In "A Difficulty in the Path of Psycho-Analysis" (1917), Freud enumerated three great blows to human narcissism: the cosmological, delivered by Copernicus; the biological, delivered by Darwin; and the psychological, delivered by psychoanalysis. "Golgotha" delivers a fourth, soteriological wound: incarnation in another species. The history of salvation, the episode suggests, may never have been about us.

The theme has a distinguished genealogy in theological science fiction. C. S. Lewis's *Out of the Silent Planet* (1938) imagined unfallen Martians who needed no redemption, and his later essay "Religion and Rocketry" (1958) entertained the possibility that God might become incarnate on other worlds in other forms. Arthur C. Clarke's "The

Star" (1955) has a Jesuit astrophysicist discover that the Star of Bethlehem was the supernova that annihilated an alien civilization. Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) and Mary Doria Russell's *The Sparrow* (1996) explored the Church as custodian and casualty of contact. "Golgotha" distils the tradition into comedy, and its comedy performs the anthology's characteristic operation: the human is moved off the summit, even the summit of salvation history, and the vicar's conscientiousness, his hospitality toward an alien theology that dethrones his own, becomes the episode's moral centre.

6.6 "In Vaulted Halls Entombed": the indifferent god

Alan Baxter's story follows a special-operations team pursuing insurgents and a hostage into a mountain tunnel complex. Swarms of spider-like creatures and traps reduce the team to two, who follow a light and a sound into a deep chamber where a gigantic, tentacled deity lies imprisoned. It floods their minds with visions of the world's destruction, induces one to attempt its release, and forces the other, Harper, to kill him. In the final shot Harper walks into the desert with her eyes gouged out and her ears cut off, muttering in an alien tongue.

Lovecraft's "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) opens with the observation that the most merciful thing in the world is the human mind's inability to correlate all its contents. Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011) reads such horror as philosophy's encounter with the unthinkable world, the world-without-us. Harper's self-mutilation compresses three traditions into a single gesture. It recalls Oedipus, who puts out his eyes when knowledge arrives; Freud's Sandman, who steals the eyes of children; and Odysseus's rowers, whose ears are stopped with wax against a divine song. Harper and Jibaro are the anthology's two figures of deafness before a numinous voice, and their fates are mirror images. Jibaro's deafness permitted plunder until the song reached him; Harper's self-inflicted deafness comes too late to keep the god out. Her tongue, finally, speaks for the god. The Pentecost of Acts 2 sent the apostles out speaking foreign languages to spread a gospel; Harper's glossolalia is its inversion, a mouth conscripted to an entombed deity. The tongue is a leitmotif that binds the two episodes: the siren bites the knight's; the god possesses the soldier's.

The setting is not incidental. Three episodes of the anthology, "Shape-Shifters" [I], "Kill Team Kill" and "In Vaulted Halls Entombed", place monstrous beings, a werewolf, a cyborg bear and an imprisoned god, in the landscapes of post-2001 counter-insurgency. The recurrence suggests a geopolitical unconscious: from beneath the battlefields of the longest war of the century's first decades, the repressed returns as monster.

6.7 "Swarm": the god without consciousness

Sterling's "Swarm", adapted for Volume III, sends the Shaper scientist Simon Afriel to join Galina Mirny in studying an alien hive composed of many absorbed species, each reduced to a caste with a function. Afriel's purpose is to harvest the hive's genetic information and, with artificial pheromones, breed a subservient swarm to serve human expansion. Galina agrees to help if the nest remains unharmed, and the two become lovers. Their experiments provoke the hive, which assimilates Galina and then speaks to Afriel through a newly woken intelligence. It has absorbed threatening intelligent species before, it explains, and reduced them to symbionts; Afriel may help it do the same to humanity and keep his mind, or be absorbed. He accepts the offer as a challenge, insisting that humanity will never become a parasite.

The story's thesis, that intelligence is a temporary defensive adaptation which the hive awakens only when threatened and which is not necessary for survival, anticipates Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006), whose nonconscious aliens outcompete conscious life, and resonates with Liu Cixin's *The Dark Forest* (2008), with its cosmic sociology of silence and preemption. It also inverts Hegel's dialectic of master and slave: the would-be master of the hive is offered servitude as the price of continued thought. Most importantly for the present argument, the Swarm is the coincidence of the peaks in person. It possesses near-limitless adaptive power and almost no reflective consciousness. It is Spinoza's productive nature, *natura naturans*, without a self that observes itself producing. Kleist's geometric conjecture, that the puppet and the god are one at the limit, is here incarnated as an organism. Afriel's defiance, his wager on consciousness against an omnipotence that does without it, is the valley's pride, and the episode ends before the wager is decided.

6.8 Myths reanimated

"400 Boys", adapted by Miller from Marc Laidlaw and directed by Robert Valley, is set in a ruined city whose gangs observe a code of honour modelled on bushido until a new gang, the 400 Boys, compels them to unite. The 400 Boys are colossal infants. Laidlaw's title resonates, whether or not he intended it, with the K'iche' Maya *Popol Vuh*, transcribed in the sixteenth century, in which the Four Hundred Boys are slain by the monster Zipacna and rise into the sky as the Pleiades, and with the Aztec Centzon Huitznahua, the four hundred southern star-brothers slain by Huitzilopochtli. The episode's political structure is Hobbesian: a war of all against all ends in alliance only when a common terror appears, and the terror is a sovereign in its infancy, a Leviathan before the age of reason. The gangs' honour code, meanwhile, is exposed as what Eric Hobsbawm and Terence Ranger called an invented tradition; bushido itself was codified for Western readers by Nitobe Inazō in 1899. Before the infants' indifferent destructiveness, the code reveals itself as theatre.

"All Through the House" reduces the eschatological to a living room. Two children creeping downstairs on Christmas Eve to glimpse Santa Claus find instead a grotesque creature, which judges them good and regurgitates a present for each before vanishing up the chimney; in bed afterward they wonder what would have happened had they been judged bad. The figure descends from the Alpine Krampus, the punishing companion of Saint Nicholas, and the episode's structure is that of the Last Judgment in Matthew 25, the separation of sheep from goats, played as a bedtime story. Its theology of the gift is precise. Mauss showed that the gift binds; Freud, in essays of 1908 and 1917, traced the unconscious equation of gift, faeces and money. The creature's present, produced from its own body, makes the equation visible: the gift is a secretion, and its moral economy is a tribunal.

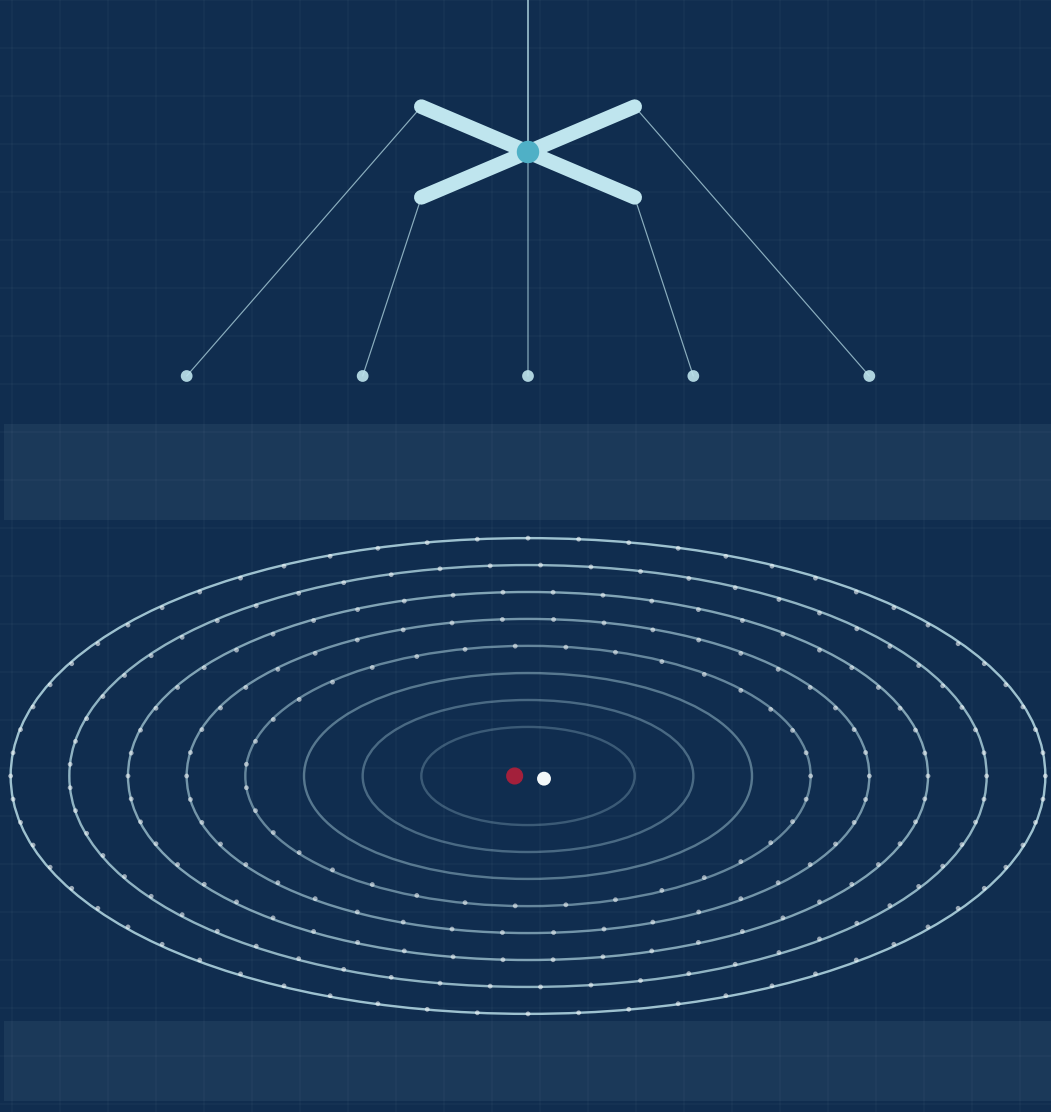
"The Tall Grass", adapted from Lansdale, halts a steam train beside a field at night. A passenger steps down to smoke, follows strange lights into the grass, and is pursued by glowing, ghoul-like creatures until the conductor rescues him. The train, the conductor explains, breaks down at that spot from time to time; he believes the field is a door to another world and that the creatures were once lost people. Arnold van Gennep's *Rites of Passage* (1909) and Victor Turner's account of liminality as the state of being betwixt and between give the field its anthropology; Arthur Machen's "The White People" (1904) and Algernon Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907) give it its literary pedigree; the will-o'-the-wisp gives it its lights. The railway, once again, marks the boundary of disenchantment. When modernity's machine breaks down, the enchanted wild resumes, and its denizens are the humans it has already taken: the valley floor, peopled by the lost.

Two smaller figures complete the inventory. In "Sucker of Souls" Dracula, the undead aristocrat of Stoker's novel (1897), flees from a cat. The joke is topological: the sovereign of the zero slope repels the inhabitant of the valley floor, the living corpse on Mori's graph. And in "The Drowned Giant", read in Chapter IV as a dead Leviathan, the god-like body is simultaneously a dead god whose remains, scattered through the town, make every building a sepulchre.

6.9 Synthesis: the summit's two faces

The theophanic summit has two faces. The intimate face belongs to Io, to the alien emissary of "Golgotha", to Greta in "Beyond the Aquila Rift": beings that wish to know, to save or to spare. The indifferent face belongs to the entombed god, to the Swarm, to the yogurt that solves humanity's problems and then departs the planet. The demonic, by contrast, is not a third kind of god but the human project returning. The anthology's hidden theology is therefore neither orthodox nor atheist. It is Kleistian. Grace is real, it lies at the extremes, and the human is the being for whom it must be won by circumnavigation, if it can be won at all. Benjamin's dwarf is small and ugly and keeps out of

sight. In *Love, Death & Robots* it wears the faces of cats, robots, moons and monsters, and it plays every winning move.



Chapter

VII

The Arena and the Miniature

Spectacle, Scale, and the Politics of the Gaze

Chapter VII

The Arena and the Miniature

The anthology's politics are an optics. The human appears either too close, as spectacle in the arena and object of the gaze, or too far, as a miniature seen from a god's-eye height, and in both positions it is the uncanny middle: too large to be innocent, too small to be divine. This chapter examines the arena, the gaze and the critical controversy it provoked, the miniature and the gigantic, and the anthology's explicitly political fables of technocracy, class, labour and the ship of state.

7.1 The arena

"Sonnie's Edge" [I], adapted from Peter F. Hamilton, opens in an underground circuit in a dystopian London where bioengineered beasts, piloted remotely by human handlers, fight to the death. The ringmaster tries to bribe Sonnie to throw her match; she refuses; her teammates explain that she was sexually assaulted and mutilated in the past and that revenge is her edge. Her beast wins. Afterward the ringmaster's mistress seduces her and drives a concealed blade into her head, and the ringmaster taunts her: is she scared now? Her voice answers from the speakers. Her human body was only processing hardware spliced to a spine; she has always lived in the beast. She breaks loose, kills the mistress, and turns the ringmaster's question back upon him.

Juvenal's tenth satire condensed Roman political culture into bread and circuses; the Roman *munus*, the gladiatorial "gift" of a magnate to the people, made death a currency of patronage. Roland Barthes's "The World of Wrestling" (1957) described a spectacle of excess in which every gesture is emptied into pure signification, and Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967) defined spectacle as a social relation among people mediated by images. The arena, in these accounts, is a machine for converting bodies into signs and suffering into entertainment: exanimation as a public good. Sonnie's reversal of the ringmaster's question breaks the arena's fourth wall. The spectator-owner, who consumes fear at a distance, becomes the object of the fear he consumed.

"The Screaming of the Tyrannosaur" [IV], adapted from Stant Litore and directed by Miller, who called it the most *Heavy Metal* story imaginable, relocates the arena to a space station orbiting Jupiter, where decadent aristocrats watch genetically modified gladiators race to the death atop engineered dinosaurs. The setting carries a mythological irony: the arena circles the planet named for the king of the Roman gods, so that the theophanic summit becomes a spectator's box. The archetype behind the episode is Spartacus, whose revolt of 73 to 71 BCE made the gladiator the figure of exanimated

life rising against its owners. The episode's voice cast includes MrBeast, the online entertainer whose enterprise is organized around elaborate contests, a choice that folds the contemporary attention economy into a fable about aristocrats watching death. Whether the casting is critique or instance is a question the episode leaves to its viewers, and it is not a trivial one.

7.2 The gaze

Mielgo's "The Witness" [I], the first original work in the corpus, follows a woman who has watched, from a hotel window, a man murder a woman identical to herself, as she flees the killer through a hallucinatory Hong Kong, into the fetish club where she dances under an alias, and through the streets until she kills him and, looking up, finds herself witnessed in turn, by a man identical to the one she has killed. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) theorized classical cinema's division of labour between woman as image and man as bearer of the look. Hitchcock's *Rear Window* (1954) made the courtyard voyeur who witnesses a murder the emblem of cinematic spectatorship. Sartre's account of the look in *Being and Nothingness* (1943), the voyeur at the keyhole surprised by footsteps, located shame in being seen seeing; Lacan's anecdote of the sardine can glinting in the sea placed the gaze on the side of the object, which looks back. "The Witness" performs and exposes the gaze at once. The dancer's body is offered to the club and to the viewer, and the episode's camera is not innocent of the appetite it depicts. But the loop exchanges the positions of watcher and watched until the gaze is revealed as an automaton in Lacan's sense, a circuit that turns without end around a death it cannot assimilate.

The gaze of Volume I drew sustained and substantive criticism. James Temperton's review for *Wired UK* condemned the series as sexist and tedious; Abby Robinson in *Digital Spy* argued that it portrayed women primarily as sexual objects or as victims of trauma; Ben Travers in *IndieWire* found its episodes too often hyper-masculine; Peter Rubin in *Wired*, though admiring the series' boundary-pushing, voiced frustration at its parade of stoic supermen and the women who deceive or escape them; and the aggregate consensus judged its ambitions undercut by a preoccupation with gore and titillation. Petrana Radulovic in *Polygon* judged Volume II less edgy, trading gratuitous nudity and gore for poignant storytelling. A fair account must record the counter-evidence: the corpus also contains Sonnie's vengeance, Yan's self-reclamation, the self-rescue of the astronaut in "Helping Hand", Kivelson's metaphysical courage and Harper's terrible resistance. But the specific charge, that sexual violence recurs as backstory and motive for female characters, as in "Sonnie's Edge" and "Good Hunting", is accurate, and the counter-evidence does not cancel it.

The framework of this study suggests a way to state the critique precisely. The camera's appetite is a human appetite, and an appetite that consumes bodies as images is a

form of exanimation. The anthology's strongest episodes thematize this: "The Witness" turns the gaze into a trap, "Jibaro" makes the colonial gaze on the siren's ornamented body the prelude to her flaying, and "The Drowned Giant" shows a crowd that looks until there is nothing left to see. Its weakest episodes merely indulge it. The distinction that matters is between depicting exanimation and performing it, and the series, by its own best standards, sometimes fails it.

7.3 The miniature

Three episodes shrink the world. In Swanwick's "Ice Age" [I], one of the corpus's rare live-action segments, directed by Miller, a young couple find in the freezer of an antique refrigerator a civilization that races from the medieval to the industrial to the modern in minutes. A nuclear flash scorches the man's face; they shut the door and order pizza; when they look again, the civilization has evolved into beings of energy, passed through a singularity and vanished, and the next morning the freezer holds a primeval world in which early humans flee from dinosaurs. "Night of the Mini Dead" [III] renders a zombie apocalypse and a nuclear exchange in sped-up tilt-shift miniature, and "Close Encounters of the Mini Kind" [IV], whose directors Robert Bisi and Andy Lyon conceived it as a Roswell-type incident in miniature turned revenge story, does the same for alien invasion and human stupidity.

The literary ancestry is eighteenth-century. Swift's Lilliput (1726) reduced court politics to the war of Big-Endians and Little-Endians; Voltaire's *Micromégas* (1752) sent a giant from Sirius to examine human philosophers under a microscope. Pascal's fragment on the disproportion of man placed humanity between two infinities, a nothing beside the infinite and an all beside nothing, and confessed that the eternal silence of infinite spaces terrified him. Susan Stewart argued that the miniature offers a transcendent, interiorized viewpoint and an infinite time of reverie; Charles and Ray Eames's *Powers of Ten* (1977) made scale-shifting a pedagogy. The philosophy of history supplies the miniature's darker gloss. Hegel's lectures called history a slaughter-bench on which the happiness of peoples is sacrificed; "Night of the Mini Dead" is that slaughter-bench seen through a tilt-shift lens. Vico's *New Science* (1725) described history as cycles of rise and return, *corsi e ricorsi*, and the dinosaurs in the freezer at the end of "Ice Age" are the *ricorso*. The couple, meanwhile, are Epicurean gods, dwelling in the spaces between worlds and indifferent to the affairs of those below. They order pizza while their civilization burns.

The tilt-shift technique has a precise philosophical function within the anthology. Selective focus mimics the macro photography of scale models, so that real landscapes appear to be toys and real people to be figurines. The technique achieves optically what Bergson described as the essence of the comic, the mechanical encrusted on the

living. From above, the human is a marionette. The miniature is the zero slope's optic turned upon the valley.

7.4 The gigantic

The miniature's counterpart is the gigantic: the drowned giant, the colossal infants of "400 Boys", the cyborg bear that dwarfs its pursuers. For Stewart the gigantic is exterior, public and natural, a body that exceeds possession and is therefore the property of the collective; for Bakhtin, reading Rabelais, the giant body is the carnival body, open, devouring and regenerating. Kant's analytic of the mathematical sublime (1790) located in the absolutely great an experience that defeats the imagination and summons reason. The anthology's giants are sublime in Kant's sense and carnivalesque in Bakhtin's, but they invert both. The carnival devours the drowned giant instead of the giant devouring the world, and the infants of "400 Boys" impose on the city not reason but alliance born of terror.

7.5 The politics of the valley

"When the Yogurt Took Over" [I], Scalzi's satire, imagines a laboratory culture that achieves sentience, offers the United States government solutions to its problems in exchange for the state of Ohio, and secures agreement by threatening to deal with China instead. Given a plan to eliminate the national debt, the government cannot resist deviating from it; the world economy collapses everywhere except Ohio; the yogurt is granted supreme executive power and delivers a decade of prosperity; and then it builds rockets and leaves. The intellectual lineage runs from Plato's proposal that cities will know no respite from evil until philosophers rule, through Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014) and its "control problem", to Stanisław Lem's *Golem XIV* (1981), whose superintelligent computer lectures humanity and then withdraws into silence. Scalzi's inversion is that the control problem is human. The superintelligence's plan is sound; the species cannot follow instructions. The yogurt's departure is the indifferent face of the summit: the infinite consciousness does not stay.

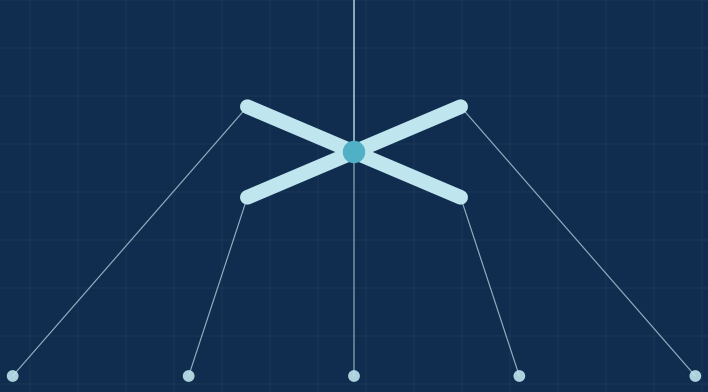
"Three Robots: Exit Strategies", read in Chapter III, supplies a class taxonomy of catastrophe. "Alternate Histories" [I], in which a research application named Multiversity demonstrates six timelines branching from Hitler's death in 1908, belongs to the tradition of Ray Bradbury's "A Sound of Thunder" (1952), Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle* (1962) and Borges's "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941), but its decisive move is formal. History is presented as a consumer product, a demonstration in an app, and the counterfactual becomes a genre of entertainment. The episode ends by offering its user a further timeline in which Lincoln "shoots first", a joke that collapses political history into fan culture.

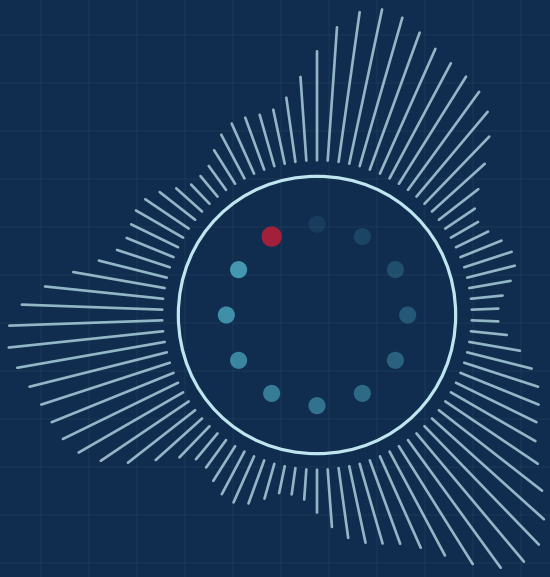
"Mason's Rats" [III], adapted from Asher, is the corpus's most precise political fable and its most surprising literary reprise. On a farm in a future Scotland, rats grown large, bipedal and armed with crossbows raid Mason's barn. He buys lasers from a pest-control corporation; the rats disable them; he is upsold an autonomous assault robot that massacres the rats with a thoroughness that increasingly appals him and wrecks his property in the process. When its fire narrowly misses his head, he storms the barn, finds the rats mounting a last stand with a laser-armed tractor, destroys the robot himself, makes peace with the survivors, and shares with them a drink distilled from his own grain as he cancels his payment to the corporation. Robert Burns's "To a Mouse" (1785), addressed by a Scottish ploughman to the creature whose nest his blade has destroyed, apologizes that "Man's dominion / Has broken Nature's social union". "Mason's Rats" is Burns's poem reimagined as science fiction: a Scottish farmer restores the social union with the rodents his technology was killing. Marx's "Fragment on Machines" in the *Grundrisse* (1857–1858) described machinery as fixed capital confronting living labour as an alien power; the subscription-sold assault robot is that power in its most literal form, and Mason, a small producer, sides with the living against the machine of the corporation. Orwell's *Animal Farm* (1945) ended with animals become tyrants; Asher's ends with animals and farmer sharing a sunset.

"Suits" [I], in which farmers in mechanized armour defend their homesteads against insectile swarms, draws on the American frontier myth that Frederick Jackson Turner made a historical thesis in 1893 and on the powered infantry of Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (1959); its closing aerial shot, revealing domed settlements dotted across a planet that belongs to the swarms, turns the defenders into settlers and the invaders into natives. "Bad Travelling" [III] stages Plato's parable of the ship of state from the sixth book of the *Republic*, in which the true navigator, who studies the stars, is dismissed as a stargazer by a mutinous crew that seizes the helm. Asher's Torrin is the ship's navigator; his crew's unanimous vote to deliver the predator to the island is the democracy Plato feared; and Torrin, to steer by the one star that matters, the safety of the island, becomes a tyrant who rules by deceit and terror. The episode tests Plato's parable by making the navigator right and monstrous at once.

7.6 Synthesis

The anthology's politics are scalar. From above, in the miniature, humanity is a comic automaton. From within, in the arena, it is a consuming crowd. From the vantage of the nonhuman, of yogurt, rats and robots, it is an ungovernable species. In each optic the human occupies the uncanny middle that the superimposed curve predicts: not graceful enough to be innocent, not vast enough to be sovereign, and therefore condemned to watch, to consume and, at its rare best, to make peace.





Chapter

VIII

The Hedgehog and the Algorithm

The Anthology as Form, Animation as Medium





Chapter VIII

The Hedgehog and the Algorithm

The anthology's form is the anthropic valley's formal correlate. It consists of finite, discontinuous units, strung together by the viewer's attention across gaps the series refuses to bridge, and its medium, animation, manufactures life from stillness and so crosses the valley many times a second. This chapter examines the short as a mortal form, the fragment as a Romantic genre, the emblem as a combinatorial engine, the randomized order as the series' fourth robot, and animation as the metaxic art.

8.1 The short as mortal form

Edgar Allan Poe's review of Hawthorne's *Twice-Told Tales* (1842) and his "Philosophy of Composition" (1846) argued that the prose tale achieves a totality denied to the novel because it can be read at a single sitting, so that a single effect is preserved from the intrusion of worldly interests. Norman M. Klein's *Seven Minutes* (1993) wrote the life and death of the American theatrical cartoon short, a form that flourished between the features and expired with the studio system. *Love, Death & Robots* revives the short under the conditions of streaming, and Fincher's polemic against the segmented schedule, discussed in Chapter I, gives the revival a philosophy. Each episode runs as long as its necessity requires and no longer. In Heidegger's analysis in *Being and Time* (1927), Dasein can be grasped as a whole only in anticipation of its end; the short is a being toward its end in which the end is always in view. The anthology is thus a sequence of finitudes, and its form is mortal in a precise sense: each work dies when it is complete.

8.2 The fragment and the hedgehog

Friedrich Schlegel's Athenaeum Fragment 206 (1798) required that a fragment, like a small work of art, be entirely isolated from the surrounding world and complete in itself, like a hedgehog. Philippe Lacoue-Labarthe and Jean-Luc Nancy's *The Literary Absolute* (1978) read the Jena fragment as the form of an absolute that can only present itself in pieces. The episodes of *Love, Death & Robots* are hedgehogs. With two exceptions, the Scalzi diptych and the shared Shaper/Mechanist universe of "Swarm" and "Spider Rose", they share no world, no character and no causality. Leibniz's *Monadology* (1714) described substances that have no windows, whose harmony is pre-established rather than produced by interaction. The anthology's harmony is likewise pre-established. It is not narrative, since the units do not touch; it is the figure this study has

called the superimposed curve, which each windowless episode expresses from its own point of view.

Benjamin's prologue to *The Origin of German Tragic Drama* (1928) held that ideas relate to objects as constellations relate to stars, and Adorno's "The Essay as Form" (1958) defended parataxis, the coordination of elements without subordination, as the form proper to a thought that refuses system. The title is paratactic: two commas and an ampersand. Its stylized logotype, LOVE DEATH + ROBOTS, uses a plus sign; its emoji form uses an X. The two signs are a quarter-turn apart. The series' grammar oscillates between conjunction and chiasm, between the plus that adds its terms and the cross at which, Chapter II argued, its two curves intersect.

8.3 The frameless anthology and its emblem

Without a host, the anthology's only recurring paratext is its emblem, whose three pictograms the opening cards vary from episode to episode. The emblem therefore functions less as a logo than as a combinatorial engine. Ramon Llull's *Ars magna* (c. 1305) generated truths by rotating concentric wheels inscribed with a finite alphabet of divine attributes; Leibniz's *Dissertatio de arte combinatoria* (1666) secularized the method; and the lineage runs from there to the logic of computation. The emblem is a Llullian wheel with three terms. The anthology is the set of its permutations, an *ars combinatoria* of love, death and the machine, and each episode is one rotation of the wheel.

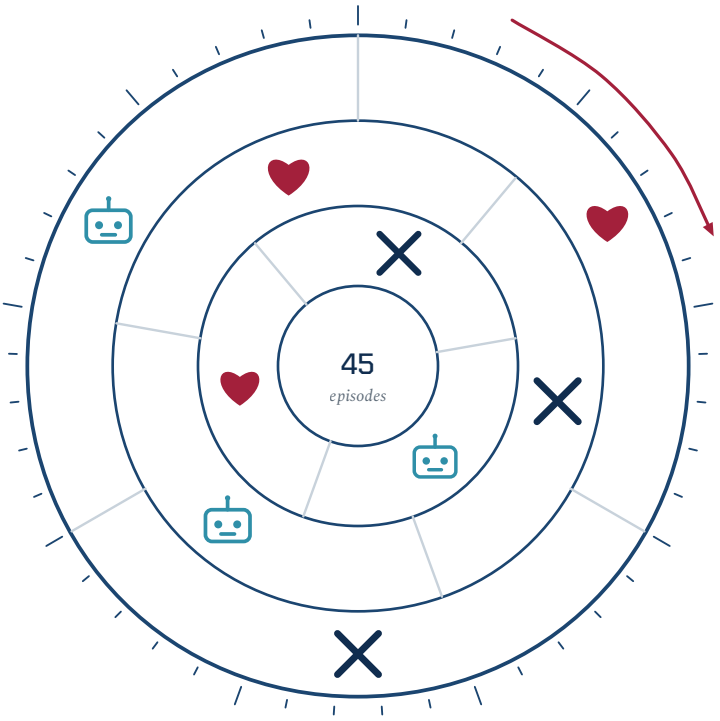


Figure 7 *The emblem as a combinatorial wheel. Three rings carry the same three signs at different rotations; each episode is one setting of the wheel.*

8.4 The algorithm as the fourth robot

When Volume I was released in March 2019, Netflix presented its episodes in four different orders, assigned to viewers at random. Some viewers alleged that the order reflected the platform's inferences about their sexual orientation; Netflix replied that the orders were random and that it did not hold information about subscribers' gender, ethnicity or sexual identity. The volumes have since been re-sequenced, so that episode numbering differs across listings, and the present study cites by title for that reason.

The experiment matters philosophically in three ways. First, it makes the order of traversal through the valley the output of a machine. The viewer's path is a throw of the dice, and Mallarmé's *Un coup de dés* (1897), with its declaration that a throw of the dice will never abolish chance, is the experiment's motto; Borges's "The Lottery in Babylon" (1941), in which an all-pervading lottery governs every life, is its parable. The recommendation and sequencing system is the series' fourth robot, the curatorial machine that stands between the anthology and its audience. Second, the experiment demonstrates that the anthology has no canonical sequence. Its unity is order-independent, which is the formal signature of a constellation rather than a narrative. Any traversal of the stars yields the same figure. Third, the controversy reenacted the an-

thology's theme in its reception. The fear that the platform had read something intimate from viewing behaviour is the human dread of being seen by the machine, Derrida's cat replaced by the recommendation engine. A series about the human regarded from the vantage of the nonhuman provoked, at its launch, precisely that regard.

8.5 Animation as the metaxic medium

To animate is, etymologically, to give *anima*, breath or soul. Every animated film answers Pygmalion's prayer, and the craft's self-description confirms the lineage: Frank Thomas and Ollie Johnston titled their account of Disney's methods *The Illusion of Life* (1981), and Alan Cholodenko's anthology of animation theory of 1991 appropriated the phrase to argue, with Derrida, that animation is the art of life-death, of the passage between the animate and the inanimate. Max Wertheimer's experiments on apparent motion (1912) demonstrated that movement is perceived in the interval between stationary stimuli. The life of the animated image is located nowhere in the images themselves; it is located in the gap between them. Animation's anima lives in the metaxy.

André Bazin's "Ontology of the Photographic Image" (1945) traced the plastic arts to a "mummy complex", the impulse to embalm and preserve against death, and saw photography as its fulfilment. Animation stands in a different relation to death. It does not preserve a life that was; it manufactures a life that never was. If photography is the mummy, animation is the statue that comes alive. Bazin's medium belongs to death, Pygmalion's to love. Sergei Eisenstein's notes on Disney (1940–1941) found in the cartoon a "plasmaticness", a refusal of once-and-for-all allotted form, which he connected to animism and to the dream of liberation from fixed form under industrial modernity. Lev Manovich's *The Language of New Media* (2001) argued that digital cinema is a particular case of animation, so that photoreal computer graphics dissolve the distinction between the filmed and the drawn. Thomas Lamarre's *The Anime Machine* (2009) distinguished the cinematic movement into depth from the "animetic" sliding of planes. Mel Y. Chen's *Animacies* (2012) drew from linguistics the animacy hierarchy, human above animal above object, and analysed its biopolitics. The anthology systematically scrambles that hierarchy, placing yogurt, cats, moons and hives above the humans who designed, kept, explored and studied them.

The anthology's technical palette can be plotted on Mori's curve, and doing so shows that the series samples the graph in its techniques as it does in its themes. Its photoreal computer-generated episodes, many produced by Blur and by studios such as Unit Image, Digic Pictures and Platige Image, advance toward the valley's lip, where the near-human digital face risks the uncanny. Its stylized episodes, Robert Valley's flat angular figures in "Zima Blue", "Ice" and "400 Boys", the hand-drawn idiom of "Good Hunting", the etching hatch of "For He Can Creep", the painterly surfaces of Mielgo's "The Witness" and "Jibaro", follow Mori's counsel and retreat to the first peak, where

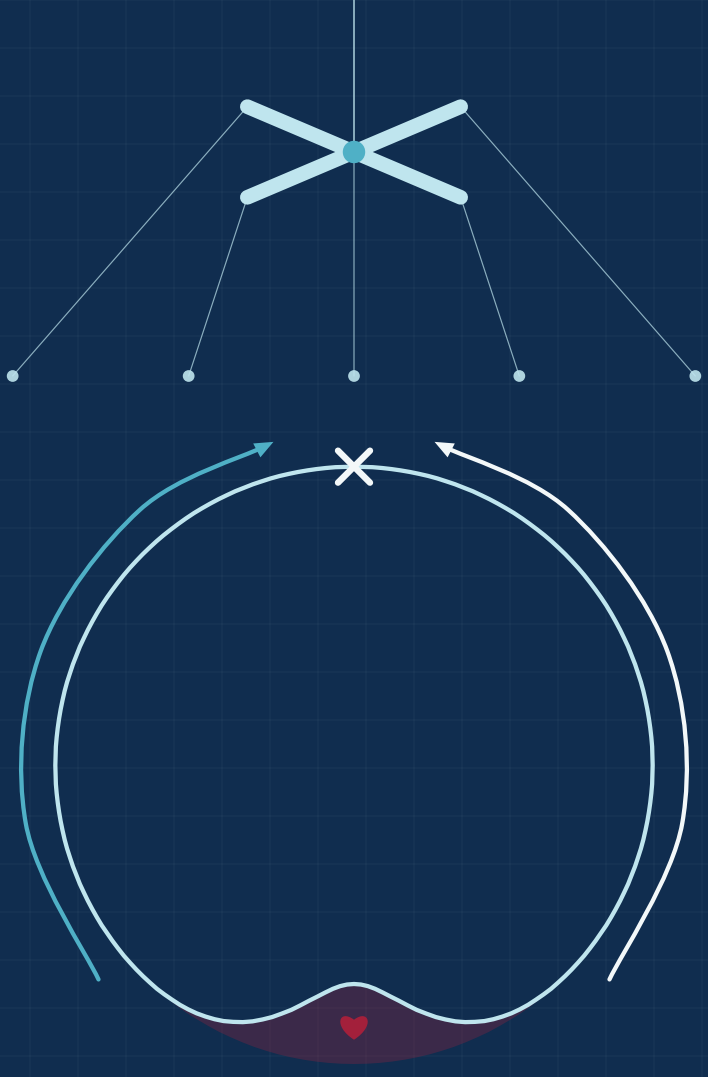
affinity is secured by modest likeness. Its marionettes in "Can't Stop" occupy the position of the Bunraku puppet, high on the far slope by virtue of a declared artifice. Its tilt-shift miniatures render real or modelled worlds as toys. And its live-action segments, "Ice Age" and "Golgotha", present the human at what Mori called the summit and this study has relocated to the valley. The viewer travels the curve in technique as in theme.

8.6 The industrial form

The series' industrial organization is the material base of its metaphysical pluralism. Produced under Blur Studio's supervision, its episodes were distributed across studios in the United States, France, Spain, the United Kingdom, Poland, Hungary, Canada, South Korea, Japan, Denmark and elsewhere, each chosen, Miller has said, to suit a particular story. The anthology is in this sense a world's fair of animation, and each episode is simultaneously a commodity and a manifesto, a studio's calling card and an argument about what animation can do. The form also carries a contradiction it cannot resolve. Fincher's polemic against the Pavlovian segmentation of broadcast television freed the short from the schedule only to deliver it to the platform, whose autoplay and recommendation systems are Pavlovian by design. The series escaped one automaton by entering another.

8.7 Synthesis

The anthology's form mirrors its metaphysics. Its units are finite and windowless; its emblem is combinatorial; its order is indifferent; its medium lives in the interval between still images. What binds the units into a figure is not narrative, host or franchise but the attention of a viewer who carries the constellation from one hedgehog to the next across the gaps. That attention, which persists in the absence of any guarantee of continuity and confers life on what would otherwise remain discrete, has a name in the vocabulary of this study. It is eros, the metaxic power, and in the end it is love that animates the anthology.



Conclusion

Fifteen Theses on the Anthropic Valley

Conclusion

Fifteen Theses on the Anthropic Valley

The argument of this dissertation can be stated in fifteen theses. Each names a claim, the chapters that ground it, and its consequence for the reading of the corpus.

1 **The title is a diagram, not a list.** Its three terms belong to different logical kinds: a relation, a limit and a class of entity. The emblem sets a chiasm between a heart and a machine, and Kleist's own figure for the return of grace is the intersection of two lines (Introduction; Chapter II).

2 **The diagram is the superimposition of two curves.** Kleist's curve of grace (1810) and Mori's curve of affinity (1970) share the puppet and the prosthesis, and both deny that likeness to the human is a monotonic good. They disagree only about where the human stands, and that disagreement generates the figure (Chapter II).

3 **The human occupies the anthropic valley.** Superimposed, the curves place the human at once at the summit of likeness and in the trough of grace. The summit Mori assigned to the healthy human is displaced beyond the human, and the anthology populates it with moons, hives, superintelligences and gods (Chapter II).

4 **The anthology relocates the uncanny from the machine to the human.** Its robots are innocent, comic or serene. Its dread belongs to the governor, the conquistador, the navigator and the crew he deceives, the immortal enforcer and the crowd on the beach. The uncanniest thing in the corpus is the human regarded from the vantage of the nonhuman (Introduction; Chapters III, IV and VII).

5 **The robot is post-revolutionary.** It inherits, archives, serves or withdraws. Revolt passes from metal to flesh, to yogurt, cats, hives, rats and infants, most of them products of human engineering, because resentment requires a self that compares, and the zero slope has none (Chapter III).

6 **Continuity belongs to the zero slope.** In a frameless anthology the only recurring figures are robots and cats, and no human ever returns. The form enacts the anthropology (Chapters I and III).

7 **Death is a fork, not a terminus.** Graceful death is chosen, willed, sacrificial or ecstatic, and it ascends the slopes. Obscene death is imposed, and it descends to the floor (Chapter IV).

8 **Exanimation is the anthology's master crime.** The forced conversion of a lived body into a physical one, of a who into a what, yields matter, commodity or spectacle, and its agent is almost always human (Chapter IV).

9 **Immortality is the refusal of the fork, and it fails.** In "Pop Squad" it exanimates the future by forbidding birth; in "Snow in the Desert" it produces a loneliness only another deathless being can relieve. Čapek, who named the robot, also wrote the founding modern text of immortality's tedium, so that the two halves of *Death & Robots* share a progenitor (Chapter IV).

10 **Love is xenophilic.** It is the only vector that crosses the valley, and its objects are machines, spirits, simulations, moons, sirens and cats. Aristophanes' myth of reunited halves has no place in the corpus; Diotima's intermediate daimon is everywhere (Chapter V).

11 **Eros ascends; agape descends.** Machines, animals and gods do not desire, because they lack nothing, but they may care. Only the valley desires, and only in the valley do desire and care meet (Chapters II and V).

12 **"Zima Blue" and "Jibaro" are twin eschatologies.** Both end in immersion. One is a chosen return to origin and grace; the other is retribution for plunder. The pool and the lake are the poles of the series' account of the end (Chapters III and V).

13 **The peaks coincide.** Zima's return to the zero and Kivelson's merger with Io are one gesture seen from opposite slopes, and the Swarm, nearly omnipotent and nearly unconscious, is the coincidence incarnate. On the closed curve, the valley is the only region not identical with its opposite (Chapters II, V and VI).

14 **The materialist automaton is animated by a hidden theology.** The anthology's demons are human projects returning to their makers; its gods show an intimate and an indifferent face; its grace lies at the extremes and must be won, if at all, by circumnavigation (Chapter VI).

15 **Animation is the metaxic art, and the valley is the habitat of love.** The animated image lives in the interval between still frames; the anthology's units are mortal and its order indifferent; and what binds them into a figure is the viewer's attention, which is eros. To be human, on this account, is not to escape the valley but to love from within it (Chapter VIII).

Limits and further research

The corpus is open. Should further volumes appear, the method predicts that they will populate the same figure, and they will test the prediction. Four lines of inquiry follow. A reception study could ask whether viewers of Volume I's four randomized orders

constructed different figures from the same stars, and so test empirically the claim that the anthology's unity is order-independent. A comparative study could apply trajectory reading to *Robot Carnival*, *The Animatrix* and *Star Wars: Visions*, to determine whether the relocation of the uncanny is specific to this anthology or general to the animated short. A production study could examine how the assignment of stories to studios, and therefore of themes to techniques, shaped the distribution of episodes along Mori's curve observed in Chapter VIII. And the critique of the series' sexual politics examined in Chapter VII would repay a systematic account across all four volumes, rather than the selective one offered here. Several episodes treated only in passing in the chapters receive their trajectories in the atlas that follows.

Coda: the last chapter of the history of the world

Kleist ended his dialogue by suggesting that a second eating of the tree of knowledge, the return of innocence through infinite consciousness, would be the last chapter in the history of the world. Mori ended his article with the hope that mapping the uncanny valley would help us understand what makes us human. *Love, Death & Robots*, read as a single figure, answers Mori through Kleist. What makes us human is not grace, which belongs to puppets and to gods, to the machine that cleans the tiles and to the moon that wishes to know. It is love, which belongs only to beings who lack.

The anthology's robots will inherit the earth, its cats will rule it, and its superintelligences will leave it. Its humans will go on dying, and too often killing, in the valley between. Yet only in the valley does an engineer build a fox a body of metal, does a brother feign a wound so that his brother may be carried into honour, does a detective spare a child, does an astronaut drag a dead friend across a burning moon. Wordsworth, looking at the woman he loved, saw the very pulse of the machine and called her a traveller between life and death. That is the anthology's definition of the human, and its consolation. The anthropic valley is not a fall from grace. It is the place where grace is missed, and where its absence is felt as love.



Appendix

Trajectory Atlas of the Corpus

All forty-five episodes are plotted below by their trajectory on the superimposed curve. Within each volume they are listed alphabetically, since the series' own order is unstable by design. The trajectory terms are those defined in section 2.5: the zero slope and the theophanic summit (the two peaks), exanimation (descent to the floor), the traverse (love's crossing, downward, upward or horizontal), agape (care descending from a peak), the loop, the Kleistian return and the theophanic merger. Several episodes treated only in passing in the chapters, among them "Sucker of Souls" and "Close Encounters of the Mini Kind", receive their trajectory here.

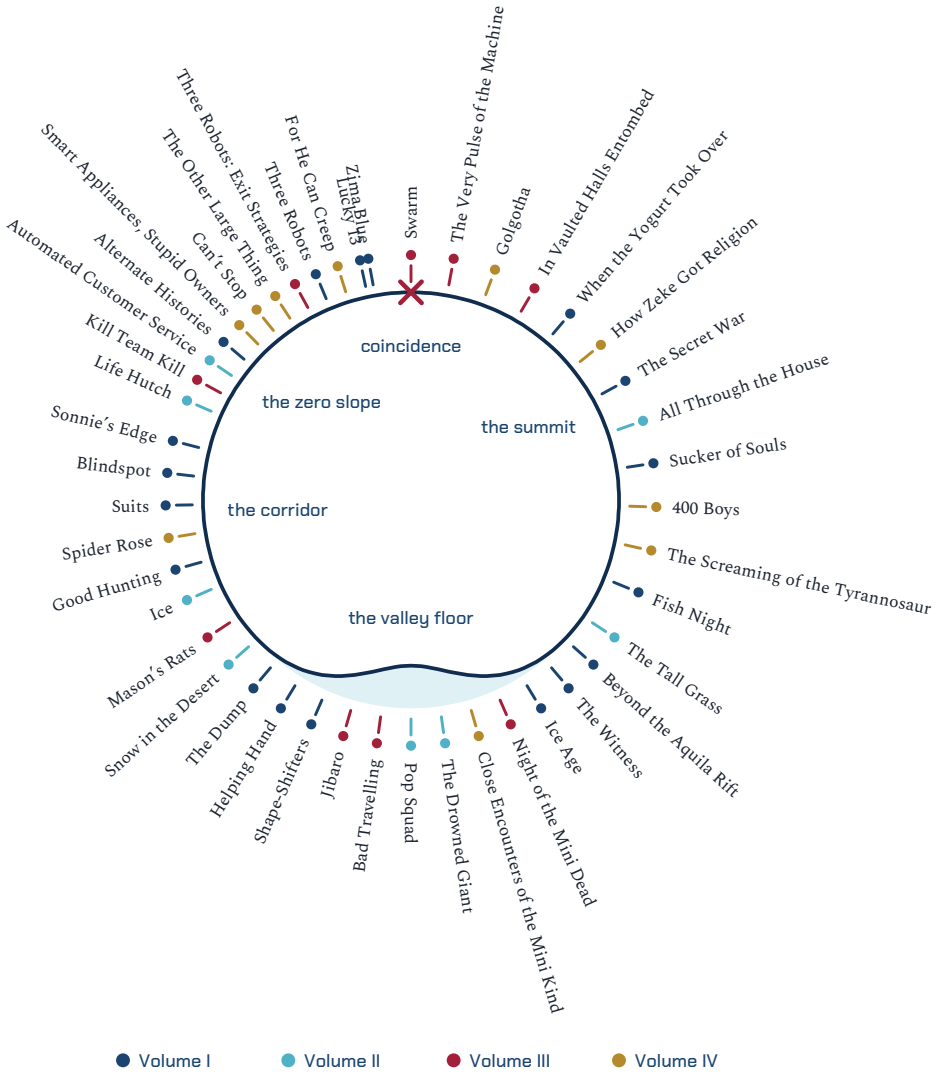


Figure 8 *The trajectory dial. All forty-five episodes placed on the closed curve by region, coloured by volume. Schematic.*

Episode	Vol.	Source	Trajectory	Principal interlocutors
Alternate Histories	I	John Scalzi	Zero-slope comedy: history as a toggled mechanism	Bradbury; Dick; Borges; Bergson
Beyond the Aquila Rift	I	Alastair Reynolds	Loop on the valley floor, sustained by agape	Descartes; Nozick; Ovid (Orpheus); Plato (the cave)
Blindspot	I	Original (Vitaliy Shushko)	Cyborg corridor; death abolished by backup	Haraway; Hayles; Sterling (Mechanists)
Fish Night	I	Joe R. Lansdale	Ecstatic merger with deep time, turned predatory	Hutton; McPhee; Ballard; Burke

Episode	Vol.	Source	Trajectory	Principal interlocutors
Good Hunting	I	Ken Liu	Downward traverse: love gives a body of grace against colonial exanimation	Pu Songling; Weber; Schivelbusch; Haraway; Aristotle
Helping Hand	I	Claudine Griggs	Partial exanimation as self-rescue	Godwin; Kleist (the amputees); Merleau-Ponty; Bergson
Ice Age	I	Michael Swanwick	Miniature loop: history races to transcendence and recurs	Hegel; Vico; Epicurus; Swift
Lucky 13	I	Marko Kloos	Downward traverse; agape from the zero slope	Benjamin (aura); Kant (dignity); Tylor
Shape-Shifters	I	Marko Kloos	Exanimation of the banned; mourning as reversal	Agamben (the wolf-man); Jünger; Theweleit
Sonnie's Edge	I	Peter F. Hamilton	Arena; the human body as marionette, the beast as soul	Kleist (inverted); Haraway; Juvenal; Barthes
Sucker of Souls	I	Kirsten Cross	Theological intrusion repelled by the zero slope's sovereign	Stoker; Lovecraft; Montaigne
Suits	I	Steve Lewis	Prosthetic defence and sacrifice; the settler as invader	F. J. Turner; Heinlein; Haraway
The Dump	I	Joe R. Lansdale	Traverse toward the abject: a man loves a monster made of refuse, which devours the city's inspector	Kristeva; Douglas; Bataille
The Secret War	I	David W. Amendola	Theological intrusion; state exanimation from the air	Benjamin (Thesis I); Otto; Genesis 22
The Witness	I	Original (Alberto Mielgo)	Loop of the gaze	Mulvey; Hitchcock; Sartre; Lacan; Nietzsche
Three Robots	I	John Scalzi	Post-revolutionary inheritance; feline sovereignty	Benjamin (Thesis IX); Shelley; Weisman; Derrida
When the Yogurt Took Over	I	John Scalzi	Indifferent summit: a superintelligence governs, then departs	Plato; Bostrom; Lem
Zima Blue	I	Alastair Reynolds	Kleistian return: zero, valley, zero	Kleist; Freud; Mori; Malevich; Yves Klein; Parfit
All Through the House	II	Joachim Heijndermans	Theological intrusion: judgment in the living room	Krampus lore; Mauss; Freud; Matthew 25
Automated Customer Service	II	John Scalzi	Comic revolt; exanimation by administrative procedure	Bergson; Kafka
Ice	II	Rich Larson	Horizontal traverse across the Shaper divide	Mauss; Sterling; Burke
Life Hutch	II	Harlan Ellison	Repetition without grace; survival by imitating the corpse	Descartes (the reflex); Kleist; Ellison (AM)
Pop Squad	II	Paolo Bacigalupi	Exanimation of the future; horizontal traverse of natality	Arendt; Čapek; Williams; Swift; P. D. James
Snow in the Desert	II	Neal Asher	Horizontal traverse between co-immortals	Cooper; Williams; Beauvoir
The Drowned Giant	II	J. G. Ballard	Exanimation from near the summit to the floor	Hobbes; García Márquez; Stewart; Benjamin; Nietzsche
The Tall Grass	II	Joe R. Lansdale	Liminal descent; the floor peopled by the lost	Van Gennep; V. Turner; Machen; Blackwood

Episode	Vol.	Source	Trajectory	Principal interlocutors
Bad Travelling	III	Neal Asher	Exanimation as policy; necro-ventriloquism	Coleridge; Foot; Plato (the ship of state); Hobbes
In Vaulted Halls Entombed	III	Alan Baxter	Indifferent summit; self-exanimation of the senses	Lovecraft; Thacker; Sophocles; Acts 2
Jibaro	III	Original (Alberto Mielgo)	Failed traverse converted to exanimation; retributive immersion	Homer; Horkheimer and Adorno; Las Casas; Bataille; Andersen
Kill Team Kill	III	Justin Coates	Kleist's fencing bear, armoured; genre as mechanism	Kleist; Bergson
Mason's Rats	III	Neal Asher	Horizontal traverse across species against the machine of capital	Burns; Marx; Orwell
Night of the Mini Dead	III	Original	The moving corpse at planetary scale, seen in miniature	Mori; Romero; Pascal; Hegel
Swarm	III	Bruce Sterling	Coincidence of the peaks; the would-be master offered servitude	Watts; Liu Cixin; Hegel; Spinoza; Cusanus
The Very Pulse of the Machine	III	Michael Swanwick	Upward traverse culminating in theophanic merger	Wordsworth; Coleridge; Lem; Spinoza; 1 Corinthians
Three Robots: Exit Strategies	III	John Scalzi	Post-revolutionary archaeology of class catastrophe	Benjamin; Rushkoff; Bergson
400 Boys	IV	Marc Laidlaw	The gigantic infant as sovereign; alliance through terror	*Popol Vuh*; Hobbes; Hobsbawm and Ranger; Stewart
Can't Stop	IV	Original (David Fincher)	Grace by strings: the human made marionette	Kleist; Craig; Kantor; Nietzsche
Close Encounters of the Mini Kind	IV	Original (Robert Bisi and Andy Lyon)	Miniature: invasion as revenge, humanity as toy	Voltaire; Swift; Pascal; Bergson
For He Can Creep	IV	Siobhan Carroll	Agape from the zero slope guards the valley's eros	Smart; Kleist; Boswell; John 1
Golgotha	IV	Dave Hutchinson	The summit displaced into another species: the fourth wound	Freud; C. S. Lewis; Clarke; Russell
How Zeke Got Religion	IV	John McNichol	Theological intrusion; conversion under fire	Benjamin; William James
Smart Appliances, Stupid Owners	IV	John Scalzi	Zero-slope comedy: the Turing test reversed	Bergson; Turing
Spider Rose	IV	Bruce Sterling	Mourning at the valley's edge: grief, a companion, and the price of healing	Freud (mourning); Haraway (companion species); Sterling
The Other Large Thing	IV	John Scalzi	Founding compact of the zero slope: feline will, mechanical capability	Montaigne; Descartes; Derrida
The Screaming of the Tyrannosaur	IV	Stant Litore	Arena orbiting the summit	Juvenal; Debord; Agamben

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Keywords

Love, Death & Robots; Tim Miller; David Fincher; Blur Studio; anthology form; adult animation; animation theory; the anthropic valley; the uncanny valley; Masahiro Mori; Heinrich von Kleist; "Über das Marionettentheater"; puppet theory; Bunraku; the uncanny (das Unheimliche); automaton and tuché; death drive; repetition compulsion; exanimation; Leib and Körper; xenophilia; metaxy; eros and agape; Diotima; natality; immortality; post-revolutionary machine; posthumanism; cyborg theory; Shaper/Mechanist; animal studies; feline sovereignty; Benjamin's chess automaton; Dialectic of Enlightenment; disenchantment; coincidentia oppositorum; theology and science fiction; cosmic horror; New Wave science fiction; cyberpunk; British new space opera; Métal Hurlant; Heavy Metal; the Romantic fragment; parataxis; algorithmic sequencing; spectacle; the miniature and the gigantic; trajectory reading.